Before the Thaw

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48842350.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Rape/Non-Con

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Angst and Fluff and Smut, Gay Panic, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Anorexia, Cutting, Self-Hatred, Self-Harm, Transphobia, Lesbian Sex, Suicide Attempt, Alternate Universe - College/University, Trans Catra (She-Ra), Friends to Enemies to Lovers, POV Alternating, idiots to lovers, Everything Hurts, Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms, Mutual Pining, Dom/sub, Dom Adora (She-Ra), Sub Catra (She-Ra), Cunnilingus, no beta we die like angella, Catra is still a cat and nobody questions it, things get worse before they get better, Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Mental Anguish, Actually Everyone Needs A Hug, Slow Burn, so much slow burn

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Before the Thaw

by LongHairCatra

Summary

Catra and Adora have been best friends for 18 years. When Adora's life gets turned upside down shortly before she leaves for college, Catra is forced to grapple with what losing Adora might mean for her.

Takes place in a college AU, heavy emphasis is placed on sensitive topics! Obligatory trigger warning: self harm, eating disorders, transphobia, dubcon, suicidal ideations, abuse (physical and psychological), and much more. Sorry, I can't resist a little angst :3

Always remember that you are loved, even if you don't know it. <3

Little Lion

Chapter Summary

Prologue

C A T R A

There was no possibility that today would go well. Not after yesterday’s disaster. Catra had started kindergarten the day before. At first, she was excited to get out of the house. To get away from *her*. But, unknowingly, Catra was set up for failure from the start.

It seemed like every other kid in her class had gone to pre-school together, something her aunt had refused to do for her. That left Catra, all alone, to sit in the corner and figure out a way to entertain herself. A little residual hope was left in her that, miraculously, she might make a friend. So she decided to draw a lion. Her mom had always told her she’d be a lion someday. Or maybe her dad…

A particularly loud shriek snapped Catra back to reality. Springs pressed into her back through the cheap leather seat, and the joyous screams of the children around her mingled with the creaks and groans of the bus beneath her, forming an overwhelming symphony of chaos.

Catra's heart felt like it was going to pound out of her chest. It was so loud, she could almost hear it through the pandemonium around her. She felt her throat close in on itself, restricting her from breathing like the zip ties Aunt Weaver used to tie her to the chair with. Her body trembled, and her hands shook uncontrollably. In this moment the school bus was her world, and her world was suffocating her with every passing second.

At some point Catra put her hands over her face. All she could see was black. Occasionally, a ribbon of color would slip through her

tightly knit fingers. The darkness was comforting sometimes: it reminded her of the best part of every day, going to sleep. Her bed was far from perfect; it was, after all, just a few old blankets on the floor. But to Catra, all that mattered was knowing she'd have seven, eight, or even nine hours of peace. Then again, the anticipation of waking up to face her aunt's impossible demands was pretty awful, too. She shivered a little.

She thought about the lion drawing clutched between her hands. It was all she had to show for her first day of kindergarten. Catra could feel heat rising in her throat, and her eyes felt dry. Then, suddenly, hot tears flowed down her face, running between her fingers and gathering at her chin. She felt a teardrop fall and land on the paper lion below. The bus, with a quick hiss, stopped suddenly. Catra was confused: they hadn't stopped here yesterday. She kept her hands over her eyes. Moments later, she felt the seat press down a little beside her, meaning her worst fear had come true: someone had sat down next to her. "Don't move, don't move," she thought to herself, tears still running down her poorly covered face. She felt a gentle poke at her side. "Are you okay?" a shrill voice asked her. Slowly, she wiped her face and lowered her hands enough to face whoever had sat next to her. "It's probably because this is the last seat," she thought to herself. Why else would someone sit next to her?

She looked to be the same age as Catra, with lightly freckled cheeks, blonde hair, and concerned blue eyes. "Are you okay?" she repeated, a little quieter this time, almost impossible to hear against the grating screams around them. Catra sniffed and, with a bleak look on her face, said "I will be."

"Why weren't you on the bus yesterday?" Catra asked the girl.

Her entire demeanor seemed to change. Her eyes got darker and she turned her face away as she responded, her voice breaking a little. "I just moved here. My parents aren't here anymore."

Catra's heart skipped a beat. This blonde girl was the same as her. "Me too," she sighed. She took the girl's hand in her own and

squeezed it.

They sat in silent solidarity for a moment.

After some time had passed, the girl let go of Catra's hand. Funny enough, Catra didn't really want her to let go. This wasn't like the times that her Aunt Weaver grabbed her hand, this actually felt… nice. The girl pointed at Catra's slightly damp drawing and asked, "what's that?"

"A lion," Catra responded, a little more bold this time.

"Wow, can I see?" the girl asked, fascinated. Catra obliged, handing over the paper to the strange blonde girl.

She studied the paper for what felt like an eternity. Catra prayed that she'd ignore the teardrops that had thoroughly saturated it, then thought to herself, "she wouldn't like it anyways. She's too perfect to like my drawing."

"I love it!" the girl declared, beaming and handing the drawing back to Catra. "I like how it has stripes down its arms, just like yours!" she said, pointing at the stripes on Catra's arms. After thinking about it for a moment, she added, "they're pretty," looking back up at her and smiling again.

Catra had never gotten a compliment like that before. She stared at the floor and blushed. "Thanks," she whispered, blushing a little. "I like your hair," she said timidly.

"Thanks!" the blonde girl exclaimed. "I want to bunch it together so it makes a little poof in the front!"

Catra looked up at the girl again, thinking for a minute. "I think you'd look good with any hair," she said.

The girl looked back at her incredulously. "Really?" she asked.

"Yeah, I do," Catra added, glancing quickly around the bus. The seat next to her wasn't the last seat after all. In fact, half the

seats were still empty.

“Maybe I will wear a poof then!” she said, puffing out her chest a little. “What’s your name? I can’t be your friend if I don’t know your name!”

Catra’s voice caught in her throat. This day was looking *so* much better than it had been five minutes ago. “Catra,” she eventually managed, still incredulous. “What about you?”

~ ~ ~

Catra and Adora did everything together.

They ate lunch together.

They played at recess together.

Halfway through Kindergarten, they spent a weekend at Adora’s foster dad’s house. Then, they spent every weekend for the rest of the year together.

They graduated elementary school, and spent every day of that summer together.

Then every summer after that.

Adora started playing hockey, and Catra showed up to every one of her games without fail.

Catra’s aunt would kick her out of the house sometimes, and she’d stay at Adora’s house while her aunt sobered up. Then, she started staying there for good. Adora’s bed was way better than that old pile of blankets, anyways.

They graduated middle school.

They made a secret hideout out of blankets and old wooden pallets in Adora's backyard, then stockpiled all the corniest movies and watched them over and over again.

Adora worked at an ice cream stand and saved up enough money to buy an old, rusty car. Its windows didn't work and it made funny noises. Sometimes they'd take it out to the beach in the middle of the night and stare at the stars.

Catra found a Ukulele in her parents' old things and learned to play. Adora, more than anything, loved lying down with her head in Catra's lap while she played her favorite songs. Adora bought her a brand new one, in her favorite shade of crimson.

Before they knew it, it was the end of their senior year together. And college acceptance letters were in.

Scars of the Past

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a letter and visits her Aunt.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra walked down the cracked and overgrown road that led to her aunt's house. It was really just a formality coming back here now - for all intents and purposes, she lived at Adora's house. She had come to see Adora's foster dad as her own, and even though he wouldn't say it, she was pretty sure he felt the same way. Catra didn't miss her aunt, and her aunt surely didn't miss her. The arrangement worked out great for both of them at first. Then, her aunt began to guilt trip her. She'd say, "You never come to see me. Do you hate me?" or "If your mother was still here, what would she think about you spending so much time with that Adora?" The comments about her mother always stung harder. But once a week, she'd drop by and, assuming her aunt wasn't drunk off her ass, hold an uncomfortable conversation for a few minutes. Just enough to say that they were still in contact with each other.

Today was different than all those other visits though: there was buzz around school that college acceptance letters were being mailed out this week, and Catra *needed* to see if she had been accepted to Brightmoon University. She didn't care too much about where she went, or even *if* she went to college, but Brightmoon was Adora's dream school. And if she was going to apply somewhere, it might as well be wherever Adora was going.

"Adora…" she thought, dreamily. The blonde filled her every waking thought these days. Adora eating a popsicle, Adora laughing and giving her that heart melting crinkly-eyed smile,

Adora fixing her car up, her shirt pulled up a little showing off her rock hard abs…

She had known for some time now that Adora was much more than a friend to her. At the start of junior year, Catra had gone to a party at Adora's insistence. "If you haven't been to a single one, how could you know you don't like them?" she had said. Catra was hesitant, knowing her Aunt Weaver's alcohol abuse and her own crippling social anxiety would be an awful combination. But eventually, she caved to Adora's pleas and obliged.

The night started off fine. The alcohol loosened her up just like it was supposed to, and she was having a good time. But Catra didn't stop drinking, couldn't stop drinking, even when she knew she knew she should have. And Adora kept drinking with her. Finally, in a half-remembered snippet of the night, the two friends had made out in the bathroom for hours, at least until Adora passed out. Maybe even a little after. Catra staggered around the house looking for something to eat, and eventually she blacked out too. In the morning, Adora didn't seem to remember any of it. But Catra knew deep down how infatuated she was, how badly she wanted to taste Adora's lips for just another second. But she couldn't. Catra knew how bad feeding her addictive personality was, and that only left one option: confessing. And if she confessed and Adora rejected her, she would lose the most important person in her life. And as sad as it was, Adora was really the only thing keeping Catra going. The only way forward was to pretend like nothing had happened.

Catra snapped herself out of it. There was time to daydream about her… best friend… later. Right now, she stood in front of the decaying mess that represented her childhood home.

It was a squat trailer with a corrugated metal roof and a porch made of old plywood. Giant rose bushes grew unkempt outside, snaking up the beaten walls and growing into whatever crevices they could find. The yard was withered and dying, not for lack of sunlight. A dead, skeletal tree was rooted in the yard on the right side, a reminder of what would happen to Catra if she stayed here

too long. She shuffled up the slab of cracked pavement that once resembled a driveway towards the door. “Home sweet home,” she mumbled to herself.

She pushed open the metal door with her foot, knowing it was never kept locked, and stepped inside. “About time you showed your face again,” a voice remarked from across the room. Catra looked up to see the figure of her aunt, clothed in her typical gaudy red bedrobe. She had hated red for her entire childhood because of that robe. The air stank of alcohol and cat piss. Bottles lay scattered across the floor, like landmines.

“Hi Aunt Weaver,” Catra said with a hint of disdain she couldn’t quite hide.

“It’s been so long my darling,” Weaver said, inching closer to her and raising her arms. Catra recoiled, and turned away from her aunt. She could feel her tail puffing up.

She narrowed her eyes and looked back at her obviously tipsy relative, making sure to stay a safe distance away. “I’m not here to see you. I’m here because I have mail that was shipped here,” she practically spat.

Her aunt chuckled, clearly overlooking her tone of voice and said, “Oh, of course my dear. I’ll have a look for it,” she said, bobbing and swaying into her half-kitchen, having forgotten about getting a hug from her very unwilling houseguest. Catra sighed heavily, pinched her fingers between the bridge of her nose, and followed her deeper inside.

She found her aunt digging through a pile of used napkins, unopened newspapers, and cut-up magazines on her cheap kitchen table. Catra could feel her throat constricting being so far into her childhood home where so much trauma, so many bad memories lay unburied. And at the center of it all was the dumpster fire of a woman sifting through a stack of garbage in the middle of her decrepit kitchen. She stopped the memories before they came rushing back to her. “Found it!” the woman

finally declared, stretching her arm out to reveal a slightly crinkled letter with, surprisingly, only a single stain on it. A proud smile stretched across her face, as though she had just completed a major achievement. “Oh, and I almost forgot…” her aunt began, before Catra flatly said, “thanks,” and strutted out the open door. She didn’t look back. She sent Adora a quick text - “got the letter, be home in a bit,” and continued on to her true home.

Catra continued her strut for a few minutes, clutching the pristine letter that held her future within. Then she realized that the sooner she arrived at Adora’s, the sooner she’d have to actually *open* the letter. Her fingers tapped against it with nervous energy. What would she do without Adora? Catra had to get into Brightmoon. If not… she let her thoughts trail off. That was a possibility she refused to entertain.

Much sooner than she would have liked, Catra reached the house. She took a deep breath and unlocked the door, leaving it to creak open slowly. Adora’s dad wasn’t home: he always seemed to be out on business trips. Catra tiptoed up the stairs, her heart trying to crawl out of her throat. She could hear Adora thumping around her room upstairs, doing something or other. She gently knocked on the door.

“Adora? Can I come in?” she called. It wasn’t like Adora to keep her door closed.

“Yeah, just a minute!” a muted voice responded. After a moment, Adora opened the door. She was a shade paler than usual, and even though she was smiling, her eyes betrayed how nervous she was. Catra didn’t want to admit it to herself, but she knew Adora’s chances to get into Brightmoon University were *much* greater than hers.

Catra desperately clutched the crumpled letter, her hands subconsciously trying to smooth it out. A small stain smudged the neat lettering on the envelope into a watery lion shaped blob. Adora’s eyes shifted to the letter, then back up to Catra. “What’d

she do, use it as a coaster?" Adora commented, trying to lighten the mood.

Catra didn't react. "Keep your composure!" her brain screamed sharply. She forced a smile.

"Yeah, I don't know. It was tossed in a pile of garbage on her kitchen table." Catra said dryly. "Have you opened yours yet?" she asked, worry flickering in her eyes.

Adora gulped. "No, I was waiting for you. I thought we should do it together."

"Alright," Catra said, sighing a little and plopping herself down at the foot of their bed. "Who's going first?" she said, trying desperately to put on a brave face.

The room was silent for a minute. They stared into each other's eyes. The anticipation in the room was palpable. "I will," Catra finally said quietly.

She sat across from Adora on the bed. With trembling hands, she unsheathed a claw and ran it along the top of the envelope. It was harder for her to breathe than when she had been at Aunt Weaver's house. Gingerly, as if it might explode, she pulled the folded paper out of it's packaging and placed it on her lap. She looked up at Adora for encouragement, who offered her a smile and a thumbs up. "Here goes nothing," Catra thought to herself.

"Dear Catra," she read aloud. She tried to keep reading on, but her eyes were glued to those two words. They refused to move down. Time felt like jelly. She could feel her head buzzing angrily, and she dropped the paper on her lap. "I can't do it!" she wailed, looking at Adora dejectedly.

"Do you want me to read it?" Adora asked gently, placing her hand on Catra's knee. It was just a fleeting moment, but it made Catra's heartbeat stop. Then, Adora withdrew her hand to her lap.

“Why’d you take your hand off?” Catra thought miserably, the letter all but forgotten. “I need a hug. I need to feel your lips on mine. I need to spend the rest of my life with you, and if this letter says what I think it does then my life might as well be over,” she sulked.

After a moment, she just replied with a defeated “yes,” squeezed her eyes shut, and balled her fists as Adora read the paper. She could feel her claws digging into the skin of her palms. It felt good. It grounded her.

“Dear Catra,” Adora read in what was clearly the most over-the-top British accent she could muster. She didn’t notice the tiny rivers of crimson slowly running down Catra’s hands.

“I hope this letter finds you well,” she continued. “As you know, the college selection process is an arduous and stressful time for both prospective students and staff.” Her voice quivered a touch on the words “prospective students.” Catra held her breath.

“We at Brightmoon University are fully committed to upholding the values and mission of our new Diversity and Equity Initiative. The student body and staff at our school are dedicated to fostering a positive and inclusive campus culture where diversity is celebrated, and each person's unique perspectives and experiences are respected and shared.” Catra’s mind filled with possibilities. Maybe, just maybe, if Adora *did* have feelings for her…

“It is with great joy and excitement that I write this letter to accept the offer of admission to Brightmoon University for the upcoming academic term!” She screamed the last part out so fast that the words blended together. A huge grin spread across her face.

Catra was floating. She was higher than the clouds. She could see the world. She felt a single tear of relief roll down her cheek. She only snapped back to reality when Adora tackled her with a big hockey-player hug. Soon, they were both laughing and crying and

smiling all at the same time, pinned down to the bed by their mutual joy. For just a moment, Catra's eyes fixed themselves on Adora's lips. She wanted to kiss her *so* bad. She wanted to tear their clothes off and get her organs rearranged. She felt a throbbing heat in her pants, then squeaked softly and changed her train of thought. She dug her claws into her palms harder.

After a few more minutes of embrace, Adora sat up and wiped the tears off her face, then gently wiped Catra's face with the sleeve of her sweatshirt. "I knew you could do it," she whispered, grinning from ear to ear. Catra was probably the happiest she had ever felt in her life. She scarcely smiled at all, let alone for this long.

"Alright tough guy, time to read yours," Catra said, trying to keep up a facade of normalcy. But secretly, she was still soaring.

Then, Adora noticed her hands. Now that her palms were exposed, she saw the pools of blood that had poured out of them and dried to her palms. "Catra?" she asked tentatively.

"Fuck," Catra said, noticing how much of a mess she had made. Her hands were still scarred with the marks of her old coping mechanism, but it had been a long time since she had actually used it. Before she could say anything, Adora was already on the move.

"I'll get some bandages!" she yelled, already halfway out of the room.

Catra sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose. "You always fuck it up," she thought to herself. Her aunt's voice snarled at her in the deepest recess of her mind, taunting her, calling her a monster and a freak and an abomination. She felt tears welling up in her eyes.

Adora rushed back in and saw Catra on the verge of tears. "Don't cry, Catra. Everything's alright. You got in, remember?"

“I’m not an idiot,” she thought, gritting her teeth. Catra hated crying almost as much as she hated herself. This was supposed to be a happy moment and she had ruined it, just like she always did. She stayed quiet and timid as Adora bandaged her hands. The rubbing alcohol hurt almost as bad as her claws did. Sometimes she felt like the only time she could get Adora to pay attention to her anymore was when she was hurting.

“Okay,” Adora said, having finished with the bandages. She sat back and admired her handiwork. Catra grumbled her thanks. It was hard to stay testy when it was clear she cared so much.

“Sorry,” Catra said, still a bit embarrassed. “I really don’t know why I-”

“Catra,” Adora said, cutting her off. “It’s alright. I promise.” Those words carried a lot of weight for both of them, so she felt a little better.

Catra took a deep breath, then said, “Alright. Your turn,” with a tight smile. This was the moment Adora had been waiting for for a *long* time. She pulled the letter back out and held it to Catra. “Would you mind?” Adora said in the same ridiculously exaggerated accent, gesturing to Catra’s claws. She unsheathed a claw and opened the letter in one swift motion, then pulled the letter out and handed it to Adora.

“Dear Adora,” Adora read, “I hope this letter finds you well. As you know, the college selection process is an arduous and stressful time for both prospective students and staff.” It was the same spiel.

“We at Brightmoon University are fully committed to upholding the values and mission of our new Diversity and Equity Initiative. The student body and staff at our school are dedicated to fostering a positive and inclusive campus culture where diversity is celebrated, and each person's unique perspectives and experiences are respected and shared.” Catra’s mind wandered to

how much Adora seemed to articulate this section. Maybe there was a chance.

"It is with great joy and excitement that I write this letter to accept the offer of admission to Brightmoon University for the upcoming academic term!" Their excitement wasn't quite so great this time: clearly both of them expected this outcome, and it was really just the formality of reading it aloud that mattered. But something was different about her letter. Whereas Catra's letter was printed on plain white paper, Adora's was rimmed on the sides with gold leaf. The writing was much more intricate. She kept reading, scanning the page as quickly as her eyes would allow her.

She coughed then, looking a bit embarrassed, continued in a hushed voice.

"I am also thrilled to share that you have been offered a full athletic scholarship to attend BU and play for the Unicorns varsity hockey team. This scholarship covers all tuition and associated expenses. I want to express my heartfelt gratitude to the Admissions Committee and the scholarship selection panel for awarding you with such a prestigious honor, and congratulate you once again on your achievements." The room became quiet again.

"Wow," Catra breathed. It was the only word that properly encapsulated the swirling hurricane of pride and bitterness that flooded her mind.

"Of course she gets a full scholarship. The golden girl, adopted into her gated community with a financially stable foster parent who also loved her," Catra thought, then immediately felt guilty. "She worked so hard. Harder than I did. She's wanted this since she was old enough to want *anything.*" But the bitterness still remained.

She managed to put on a happy face and say, "Congrats, you really made it. You're in the big leagues now," pulling her into a hug.

A flash of hesitation lit Adora’s face, then she went back to smiling and hugged Catra back, much tighter than the smaller girl could have hoped for. Catra smiled. Everything was right in the world. Well, everything that mattered anyways.

Until it wasn’t.

The two sat, enjoying one another's embrace for a few more moments, before they decided to read through the rest of their letters.

“Uh, hey Adora?” Catra said nervously. “You know how on the application there was a slip to dorm with someone if you knew them beforehand?”

“Yeah, what about it?” Adora responded.

“I didn’t see anything about it in this letter.”

Adora brushed it off. “Of course it’s not in here, this was just the acceptance letter. It’s all formal and fancy,” she said, mockingly pointing at the gold leaf. “They wouldn’t include anything like that in here.”

Catra sighed. “Okay, if you’re sure,” she huffed. Then they hugged again, staying in this embrace for much longer.

Chapter End Notes

Surely nothing bad will come of this...

Old Games

Chapter Summary

Things get worse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first days of their senior summer flew by, much to Catra's dismay. They spent long nights together on the beach, staying up late and talking about everything under the sublime night sky. Catra went to visit Adora at the ice cream stand, and she'd always sneak her a big cup of vanilla custard through the window. A week after their high school graduation, Adora got a phone call from one of her foster dad's work associates. He had fallen ill while he was on a business trip, and he was too unwell to travel home. The diagnosis was still unknown, but it didn't look good. Adora, understandably, wanted to visit and make sure he was doing alright. And so, the two parted ways in a tearful exchange, unknowing of the true scale of his condition.

It was radio silence for days. Catra stalked her phone day and night, scarcely leaving their room. Then, on the fourth day, Adora sent a single text message: "I don't think I'll be back this summer."

They called and caught up that night. Her father had a condition called Disseminated Intravascular Coagulation. The cause was unclear. He was stuck in the ICU and would need to stay intubated for a long time. Adora was clearly on the verge of tears, even days after learning of the disease: his prognosis really wasn't good. Catra didn't know what she could do to possibly comfort her. Adora had lost both of her parents as a child, and now she might lose a third. "I might lose a third," Catra thought to herself. Adora's foster dad was just as much her own in every sense but legal, and knowing she couldn't be there with him hurt. Bad. Still,

Catra tried to stay strong for Adora. She joked and redirected her to happier thoughts, reminding her that college was only a few months away. Then, all too soon, their call ended. Adora promised to call again in the next couple days.

Catra tried desperately to keep herself busy. She stared at a list of majors that BU offered for hours on end, waiting for an answer to leap off the page at her. It didn't.

She took care of the now empty home to the best of her ability. Not for herself, but for Adora's family. It seemed so devoid of life in their stead, but where else was she supposed to go? Aunt Weaver's shack? No way was she going back to visit with all the new concerns swirling around her head.

She played the Ukulele, most of the time alone. It was nice pretending Adora was still there, but Catra missed the soft tendrils of hair, the warm head resting on her lap. Most of the time she couldn't finish the songs she used to play for Adora. But she always played at least one song for her during their Saturday phone calls.

She filled in for Adora at the ice cream stand. She was making a little pocket money, too. It was a long walk without a car, but what else was Catra going to do?

Slowly, she felt herself slipping away into half remembered habits from when she lived with her aunt.

First came the cutting.

Much like the day when they had opened their letters, Catra would sink her claws into her own skin without even realizing it until her body was covered in deep crimson stains. Sometimes she'd let them bleed. Sometimes she'd open them up on purpose.

Then came dissociation.

More and more often she'd find herself shuffling around the desolate house or lying in bed for hours, desperately missing

Adora's scent which had long since faded from their sheets. Some days she wouldn't be able to remember anything about the previous.

As sad as it was to admit, Adora was the only light in her life. Catra was completely lost without her, and she hated herself for it.

Then came her most humiliating habit. Before Adora had left, when Catra was in heat she'd sleep in the guest room. It was a good solution, because she would never forgive herself if her subconscious mind had acted on *any* of the thoughts she had towards Adora. Adora was always a bit confused, but thankfully never pushed the subject. Catra, having nothing else to do, fully embraced her heat cycle, spending hours in their bed moaning Adora's name into the pillows and edging until her entire body shook.

Catra hated masturbating. So much. She hated her body, the fact that she was born with a penis. It felt so wrong, and she still bore the scars of when she had tried to cut it off with her own claws as a child. She hated the fact that it made her less than any other woman on the planet. She always had to remind herself that, even if Adora *did* like women, she'd never like Catra. Ever.

Saturdays quickly became both the best and worst days of the week. Best because she knew for one blissful hour in the evening, she'd get to speak with the only person capable of beating back the inky darkness that had swallowed her old life. Worst because, at the end of that call, she knew the next one was one hundred sixty seven excruciating hours away.

She tried to convince herself that, however awful she felt, Adora probably felt a hundred times worse.

She really did try.

~ ~ ~

Thirty three days and six hours after Adora left, Catra found a letter in their mailbox addressed to Adora. It was from Brightmoon

University. She frowned, wondering what it could possibly be. She texted Adora and asked what it was.

"idk, open it and lmk," was the response she got five minutes later from a clearly distracted Adora.

Catra did exactly that. She took it up to their room, and tore it open in much the same manner as she had done a little over a month ago, hungrily reading the information within.

Dear Adora,
We hope this letter finds you well and eagerly look forward to the start of your journey at Brightmoon University. As you surely know, one of the most exciting aspects of college life is the opportunity to build connections and form lifelong friendships. We are delighted to inform you about your roommate assignment for the upcoming academic year.

After carefully considering the information provided in your housing application and taking into account your preferences and compatibility factors, we are pleased to announce that your assigned roommate is:

Name: Glimmer

Major: Theater

Catra's heart stopped. Her face turned three shades paler and she dropped the letter, scarcely noticing as it fluttered to her feet amidst the piles of discarded clothes and takeout containers. Not a single thought ran through her head, and she sat paralyzed for a long time. The buzz of her phone, it's quiet hum reverberating through the silent room, eventually pulled her back to reality. A reality where she could feel Adora slipping away from her. A reality she didn't want to live in. She didn't even check her phone.

Instead, she pulled a pair of Adora's tennis shoes out from under their bed and started running to her Aunt Weaver's house.

It had been over a month since Catra had visited, but she knew there was something important sitting on that crusty, stained dining room table. She trembled a little as she ran. Her head was foggy and it felt impossible to focus on anything but putting one foot in front of the other as the road gradually became filthy and shattered around her. After some time, she stood at the foot of the ramshackle trailer her aunt called home. Her phone buzzed again, nearly coaxing her from her trance-like state. Ignoring her phone once again, she stepped inside.

The trailer was dark inside. Her aunt lay passed out on the couch, wearing only a ratty pair of pants and a wine stained bra. The television in front of her blared nothingness. Catra quietly advanced forward to the dining room, avoiding the empty bottles haphazardly strewn about the room like landmines. She quickly made it to the kitchen table. The same pile of trash sat on the plastic table, although this time it was slightly larger. Most of the magazines hadn't been touched since Catra was here last, she guessed, seeing the thin layer of dust that had settled on them. She dug through the pile, trying to find the envelope that surely lay inside. Shuffling a coupon book to the side, she accidentally knocked a stray bottle off the table, shattering on the filthy ground with a loud "Crash!" and coating Catra's legs in a vaguely alcohol-smelling liquid. She heard movement in the room behind her. Cursing under her breath, she hastened her search, only to hear her aunt speaking behind her a moment later.

"You disappear for a month, and this is how you greet me?" she said, her eyes dull and mouth turned downwards into a frown.

Catra sighed and pressed her fingers to the bridge of her nose. "Look, Adora's been going through stuff and I've been doing my best to help out, and-"

"It's always Adora with you, isn't it?" her Aunt mused. "I don't know why she still humors a freak of nature like you. Lord knows I

shouldn’t either,” she mused, half to herself.

Catra’s tail puffed up, and she turned back to the table. “Listen, I need to find my mail and then I’ll get out of your hair. Go back to sleep.” She moved a few more papers to the side.

But she could still hear her Aunt moving closer to her. “You don’t deserve *your* mail. It came to *my* house, and you snuck in uninvited like the brat you are. I think you should leave,” she said, her frown twisting into a smirk.

Catra frantically dug through the bottom of the pile, finally finding a letter, much like Adora’s, but addressed to her. She turned around, letter in hand, and spat, “Thanks, bye.” But her Aunt had other ideas.

As Catra sped toward the door, she felt her phone buzz again in her pocket, and she hesitated for a moment, giving her aunt just the window of time she needed to lunge and grab one side of the letter. The two grappled one another, and knocked over the single wooden chair beside the table. “I told you, this is *mine.*” she said in a terrifying voice, slowly prying the paper from Catra’s claws.

“Why can’t you just be normal? Let me go.” Catra whined. She didn’t have the patience for this right now. She had to get out of this house before she snapped.

“Oh, like *you’re* so normal?” her aunt jeered. “All you’ve ever done is hurt everyone around you. Your friends all abandoned you, and if they haven’t yet, then they will, sooner than you think. I’ll be all you have left and you’ll crawl on back to me, just like you always do. You’re an abomination, and you know you’ll never be like the other girls. Adora never liked you in the first place. All she’s ever done is humor you.” Her dull eyes seemed to bore into Catra’s very being. Catra was frozen in place as she spat out insult after insult.

Catra screamed and yanked the letter away as hard as she could, tearing it in half. Then, she sprinted out of the house, crying so many tears that she couldn't see straight. The sun was setting now, and the only light was cast by the occasional street lamp along the sidewalk. She ran for a while, then collapsed onto the pavement, curled up into a ball, and sobbed. Loud, gut wrenching sobs that shook her entire body. She retched a few times, but nothing came up. She hated herself, and she hated that everything Aunt Weaver had said was true. She was an abomination. She was unwanted, unneeded. She was a burden, and a freak of nature. Adora had never loved her, and would never love her.

After she had cried out all her tears, Catra trudged to Adora's house. The sky was dark now, and not a single star shined through the thin haze of clouds covering the moon. She collapsed into their bed, gently removing her half of the letter from its shredded outer layer. She scanned over it through her tear-blurred eyes.

It was the bullshit opening congratulations.

The other half, the one with her roommate's name, was still in the trailer.

Her vision went red.

She unsheathed her claws. They were still caked in dried blood.

Her phone buzzed again, but she didn't notice it in her blind panic.

Catra tore into her legs, deep, until there was a pool of dark, sticky crimson between her and the sheets.

She dry sobbed until she passed out in Adora's bed.

It was only the next morning when she got up to take her medicine that she realized she had missed their weekly phone call.

Chapter End Notes

After this chapter the POV switches to Adora for a bit.

I'm sure Catra will be fine.

Borrowed Time

Chapter Summary

Adora spends some time with her foster dad.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A D O R A

Adora sat on the corner of the hospital bed, staring out the large window to her right. She wasn't looking at anything in particular: this was just her only way of escaping the brutal reality that she had been forced into.

She had sat in this hospital day in and day out, and she had grown to hate everything about it. The sterile smell to the air, the pastel yellow walls and contrasting lilac curtains. Even the food was tasteless. And beyond it's physical attributes? This place only represented the death of her father, of her summer with Catra, and of her old life in its entirety. Adora let out a long sigh. She wasn't the one suffering the most here, and it just wasn't right to have such selfish thoughts when the man who had raised her lay slowly dying a few feet away from her.

"Something wrong?" an all too familiar voice rasped behind her. She turned her head and saw the once-handsome man looking at her, clearly expecting a response. His eyes were sunken in, his hair patchy, and his skin almost translucent.

The physical deterioration had been something she had been warned of in the first days of his hospitalization, but it was almost impossible to find any resemblance between the confident, handsome man who had raised her and the skeletal figure lying in the pale blue bed. He had easily lost fifty pounds in the last two months, maybe more. Adora shivered at the thought.

Despite the frail state of his body and intruding beeps of the machines beside his bed, he didn't appear to be in pain. Death was bad no matter which way Adora looked at it from, but watching her adopted father clawing desperately for just one more day was especially heartbreaking.

She forced a smile. "Nothing new, dad. Just the same old stuff." Because what else could she tell him that he didn't already know?

He looked up at her, sadness in his eyes. "I'm sorry. You shouldn't be stuck in here during your senior summer. You should be out with Catra, having the time of your lives doing lord knows what." He had said something like this almost every day Adora visited him. Much like herself, her father had the bad habit of blaming himself for every shortfall in other people's lives.

"Dad, no!" Adora protested, standing up from the foot of the bed and crossing her arms. "Catra will be there when I get home." Then she realized what she said. What she implied.

Her father grimaced. They both sat in silence for a moment.

"I always liked Catra," he said abruptly. "She's lucky to have a friend like you. She was always like a second daughter to me."

Adora felt a familiar pang in her heart when she heard the word "friend." Her throat felt dry, and she nodded her head. "I've been keeping up with her, you know. We still call each other. It's good for both of us." She hated lying to her dad, but she didn't have the heart to tell him that Catra had stopped talking to her a few weeks ago. The last text she had sent said, "there's a letter here with your name on it." And then it was as if she dropped off the face of the Earth. Nothing about it made sense. Adora texted her frantically for a few days, praying for a response, any response. She even called outside of their dedicated times. She had asked one of her old friends, Kyle, if the lights were still on at the house, and he said they were. So it seemed that Catra was intentionally avoiding her, which hurt almost as bad as seeing her father in his current state.

Her relationship with Catra was… complicated, even before she had ghosted Adora. Complicated, yet so simple. They had been best friends since she could remember. But recently? Adora wasn't so sure if that was the right word for them anymore.

She had a crush on Catra ever since that day on the bus, with the lion picture. Everything about her was perfect. Her contrasting eyes, the little hair tufts around her ears, the way she laughed. Adora knew how poorly she saw herself too, so she tried to make sure to give her as much reassurance as she could. And it broke her heart knowing that Catra didn't take any of it to heart.

They were both completely different people now, but Catra was still so *Catra*. Adora ran a hand over her hair, pushing down her poof and feeling it spring back up. If only she hadn't been so selfish that fateful night 2 years ago, everything would still be so simple. She wanted to beat the memory out of her head even now. She had convinced Catra to go to that party, convinced her to drink, to get drunk, and all for what? A half remembered night of sloppy kisses that smelled like vodka? Thinking about it made her want to throw up, even now. Clearly Catra didn't remember anything, because she never brought it up after the fact. That was the last party Catra ever went to. And that was the last party Adora ever willed her to go to.

"See, there you go again, disappearing into dreamland. What are you thinking about?" her father asked, sitting up a little straighter and wincing.

"Nothing!" Adora said quickly. The man's blank face clearly showed that he wasn't buying it.

"I want to know," he said, silently implying "before it's too late." He continued. "You've been more distant for a few weeks now, and that's not like you at all. You know you can talk to me about anything, right?"

Adora pondered what she could tell him. She didn't want to distress him any further than he already was, so the situation with

Catra was out. “Out…” Adora thought to herself. Her eyes lit up. Her heart pounded a little faster. This wasn’t how she had planned this moment out, but it was as good a time as any. She took a deep breath, and turned to her father. “Dad?” she asked, her heart beating in sync with the beeps of the machines in front of her.

“Yes Adora?” he said dryly.

She squeezed her eyes shut, bracing herself for whatever his reaction would be. For a moment, it was as if her soul slipped out of her body and she was watching the moment play out from above. Her mouth opened, and she uttered two words:

“I’m gay.”

He didn’t say anything. She kept her eyes scrunched shut. “This isn’t how this was supposed to go,” Adora thought to herself. He was supposed to say “that’s fine, I love you and I always will.” Then, she heard the last noise she thought he would make: laughter. Hearty, healthy chuckles that she hadn’t heard leave the sickly man’s body in months. She opened her eyes.

He was smiling. Smiling and laughing so hard, he had tears in the corners of his bloodshot eyes. Adora sat watching him, red faced from embarrassment. When he managed to get control of himself, he said, “I know, kiddo. I’ve known for a long time.”

“How?” Adora asked incredulously. She didn’t believe it. All this time, she thought her dad was oblivious.

The man smiled again. “You’ve always been bad at hiding things, you know. I remember when you were seven, you asked me if girls could marry other girls. Then when I said yes, you asked if you could marry Catra.”

Adora blushed even harder.

“Did you know,” he said, raising an eyebrow, “that I’ve never once seen you check out a man? It’s only ever been other girls. And not

that I know your type, but Catra is definitely it," he added with a smirk and a nudge.

"Hey!" Adora said, but her dad still wasn't done.

"And then there's those magazines I found a couple months ago when I was cleaning your room…"

"Okay, that's enough!" Adora shouted, prompting a nurse to pop her head in and tell her to quiet down.

"You need to love who you love," he concluded. "Whether that be Catra or another wonderful woman in the future, as long as you're happy, I'll be happy. Life is too short to be unhappy." He let out a heavy sigh as he slowly rested his head back against the pillow.

Adora sighed too and, after a moment, asked timidly "Are you happy?"

The man smiled. "You make me happy, kiddo. You're the best decision I ever made. But I wish I had done some things differently."

"Like what?" Adora asked. Her adoptive father was a kind man, but he never really talked about his past, or the business that seemed to occupy so much of his time.

"I've been thinking about my husband a lot these past two months," he continued, his voice lowering to a hoarse whisper. He talked about his deceased spouse least of all, whom Adora had never even known. She was attentive as she could possibly be, all joking from the moments prior forgotten.

"His last days were quite the opposite of mine. Normal. His end was sudden. Nobody expected it," he said, the faintest of tears glistening in the corners of his eyes. "Not much time for contemplation or reflection. I was on a business trip when he passed. I hadn't seen him for days. My last words to him were talking about a grocery list," he said with a little chuckle. A tear

finally rolled down his cheek. “I don’t know which is better, a sudden death or a drawn out one.”

Adora didn’t know what to say, so she just clutched his hand as he kept talking. She was seriously in danger of crying.

“He would have liked you, I’m sure,” he said with a smile and a glance at her.

She started to cry. The man continued.

“Adora, you’re going to go through rough times. I want you to know, I need you to know,” he said, grabbing her arm and waiting until she looked at him again, “that no matter what, you are loved. that I am watching over you, and that everything will work out in the end.”

He sat up a little straighter and wiped his eyes. “I wish I had done something I enjoyed instead of taking over *my* Dad's business. It took over my life, and it’s hard looking back and knowing that I could’ve spent so much more time with the man I loved. And sure we’re well off for it, but money doesn’t mean much if you hate how you make it. I dissolved the business. I don’t want you to follow in my footsteps. You’ll be getting all the money I made from selling its shell companies, which should be enough for you to live comfortably for a long time.”

Adora didn’t know what to say. The news blindsided her. She had never really considered what would happen when he passed on, but it certainly wasn’t this. The tears really started flowing now, and heat started rising in her throat. “Dad…” she said, but she didn’t get the opportunity to say anything else.

“I’ve thought about this day for a long time, Adora. No child deserves to watch three of their parents die.” He started crying softly again. “Your school starts in two days. I want you to enjoy your life. Play hockey at Brightmoon. Be with Catra. Move on the best you can.” A lone tear streaked down his face.

Adora was sobbing now. She hugged the man as hard as she possibly could, eliciting a quiet, strained wince from him. “I love you so much,” she said, the words barely audible through her strained voice.

They stayed in mutual embrace for a long time, trying desperately to ease the pain. Then the man broke off. “Go,” he said with tears in her eyes. “I love you,”

Adora took one last look at him through blurry eyes, then walked out of the room.

He passed away that night.

Adora gathered her things to go home the next morning.

Chapter End Notes

> So when I decided I wanted to write this fanfic, I was on the waitlist to make an AO3 account for a few days. This is the last chapter that I had drafted during that wait, so the next few will be spaced out a little more.
>
> This is not me saying that I'm abandoning the work, far from it. I'm beyond glad that so many people are enjoying it, I just won't be uploading 4 chapters a day.
>
> <3

Reunion

Chapter Summary

Adora returns home

The morning after her father's passing was little more than a blur of hazy memories for Adora.

Desperately tossing and turning, trying to get a few minutes of rest without thinking about him.
Picking up the meager belongings scattered about the room as the early morning light crept into her room.
Answering a phone call from some nameless representative explaining the terms of the will, insurance payments, IRAs, public records, and a million other things she was too exhausted to care about.
The hotel lobby that seemed to grow longer with every aching step she took, and eventually the gentle squeak as the automatic doors opened.
The gust of warm air that hit her as she opened the car door her father had helped her reattach so long ago.
Pulling out of the empty parking lot to start the arduous eight hour drive that lay ahead of her.

As the hotel faded from view in her rear-view mirror, she whispered a silent farewell to her old life. Anything would be better than the past two months.

~ ~ ~

The blonde girl sat behind the wheel of her car. Deep, black bags hung under her eyes like the shadow of death. It took every ounce of energy she had in her to keep her eyes on the road. "Only six more hours," she muttered to herself. Six hours until what? Until she saw Catra, her best friend, who had inexplicably ghosted her? Until she returned to a house full of memories she

just wanted to forget? She closed her eyes for a second. She was so tired…

A loud car horn woke her up after what might've been a split second or a few minutes. She had almost run off the road. Fixing her eyes firmly on the road again, she continued on, a bit slower this time.

Her brain went in circles as she tried to work out what Catra was mad at her for. She just couldn't come to a conclusion that made any sense, and the only thing Adora could remember was the flash of animosity in her gaze when she had received her scholarship. But there was no way that could have upset her that much, right? But if it did have to do with a letter…

She had texted Catra that morning telling her she was coming home. Even if Catra didn't want to talk to her, she still had to get to Brightmoon *somehow,* presumably in Adora's car. They'd talk things out, everything would be fine, and maybe they could even put their beds together in their dorm. Her heart fluttered a little at the thought. Even in the summer heat, her bed at the hotel had felt unnaturally cold without Catra there to share it.

Adora fidgeted with the radio, trying to find anything to soothe her nerves or keep her awake. As she mindlessly flipped through the stations, she heard the opening of a hauntingly familiar song. A flood of emotions and memories rushed through Adora's mind, transporting her back to a party two years ago. Adora could hear music blaring, feel the cold tiles beneath her, taste Catra's lips, her wet tongue, the vodka on her breath...

Then all too soon, it was over. Adora had nearly swerved off the road. Again. "Focus!" she shrieked at herself, pounding her hands on the steering wheel. The last thing she needed right now was a totaled car.

Despite trying to concentrate on the road, her mind started to wander again after a few minutes. She hadn't seen Catra drink since that day. And it had only been after the party that Catra fully

explained her Aunt's alcoholic tendencies, the main reason she was so afraid to drink. "If only I hadn't been so selfish…" Adora thought. Then she found herself replaying her father's words over and over again in her head: "Not that I know your type, but Catra is definitely it." Adora felt tears coming on and pulled over to the side of the road again. It had been a few miles since she'd had a good cry, anyways.

~ ~ ~

She finished the eight hour drive in a little over thirteen. Any energy that she thought she had left before the drive was completely exhausted. As she pulled into the driveway, she glanced at the clock on her car radio. It was 11:48 at night. She took a look at the house to see if anything was out of place. Everything seemed normal, just as Kyle had reported. She opened up the garage door and slotted her car in the empty spot beside her father's. A thin film of dust had settled over it, and she couldn't help but wonder what would happen to the house and the rest of their belongings, before remembering how thoroughly the man had planned for his own death. He really was a good dad.

Taking the first step out of her car, Adora almost fell over. She'd neglected to eat anything today, and abruptly standing up was seemingly too much for her body to handle. Grabbing onto the car roof for a moment, she took shaky steps towards the door. The air was musty in here, which made sense. Catra didn't drive, so she wouldn't have had any reason to come in here. "Catra," Adora whispered longingly. She was probably asleep, so they'd have to sort out whatever she was angry about in the morning. The few brain cells that were still functioning in her head cycled through all the possibilities as to why Catra was mad at her as Adora stepped into their proper house.

Shutting the side door behind her, Adora flipped on a light. It was unsurprisingly a bit messier than when she had left: Catra wasn't exactly known for being the cleanest. Walking into the kitchen, Adora looked through the cupboards for something to sate her

growling belly. Pulling out a cup of ramen noodles, she turned to grab a drink from the fridge when she noticed the slightly ajar basement door. "Interesting," Adora noted to herself. There wasn't anything down there except the incredibly unorganized storage and her dad's cellar, so she couldn't imagine why Catra would've gone down there.

The microwave seemed ten times louder than normal as its quiet hum resonated through the empty house. Adora found herself nodding off standing up at the kitchen island, her mouth watering as the smell of delicious processed noodles began to fill the air. She quietly opened it when there was a second left on the timer to avoid the grating beeps it made upon completion. After all, Adora didn't want to wake the potentially sleeping Catra.

Quickly slurping down the noodles, Adora tossed the styrofoam cup into the trash. She had a long day of packing ahead of her the next day, so she crept up the stairs as quietly as she could. Slowly, she tiptoed down the hallway towards their room and slowly opened the door. Much to her surprise, Catra was nowhere to be seen.

She turned around and pressed her ear against the door of the spare bedroom, right across the hall. Sometimes Catra slept in there for some reason she refused to disclose. Sure enough there were muffled noises coming from the room, indicating that Catra was inside.

Entering their room again, Adora was taken aback by how spotless it was. Everything was in perfect order. The sheets were even folded back, something Catra usually refused to do, leaving the task to Adora. She also noted that the sheets were a different color. Nothing made sense, but Adora was too tired to ponder any further. She shut the door behind her and collapsed onto the bed.

Adora woke up the next morning still exhausted, but a little less so than the day before. Her stomach screamed profanities at her. Clearly last night's noodles hadn't been enough. As she got out of bed and turned on the bedside lamp, she surveyed the room.

Her battered old hockey stick hung on the wall, trophies and ribbons carefully displayed on shelving above it. Pictures of her and Catra hung on the wall too, printed and cut out like old polaroid photos. Catra's ukulele hung on the opposite wall, with her own collection of pictures pinned around it. A small bookcase and desk sat in between the sides, which the two would share when they did homework. Various posters of their favorite movies hung around the room, too. And finally, above the window sat a poorly drawn lion, attached to the wall with peeling, yellowed tape. When she was little, Adora couldn't have imagined sharing a bedroom with anyone. And despite having to for the last two months, she now detested sleeping alone. She sighed, thinking back to the days when everything was so much simpler…

Her attention fell back to the bed sheets. Whereas before she left they had been a pale yellow, now they were navy blue. She'd have to ask Catra what happened to the old ones later.

Leaving the bedroom she noticed the guest room door was still closed, but she noticed something she hadn't seen last night: an empty bottle. She pressed her ear up against the door, trying to listen for signs that Catra was still inside. Sure enough, noises were coming from inside the room. Strangely distressed noises. Muffled grunts and moans. Adora's heart leapt into her throat. She remembered passing by the open cellar last night. Then thought about how Catra had suddenly gone silent. Catra's isolation, the basement door, her sleeping in a separate room. It all made sense. "She's drinking again," Adora said dejectedly, "and she must be hungover." It was distressing that the cat would choose to drink again knowing how much it had scarred her in the past, and Adora wanted to help her.

Taking a deep breath, Adora cracked the door open. The smell of alcohol wafted out of the room. Feeling reassured in her assessment, she pushed the door open the rest of the way. She almost couldn't believe the scene before her.

Bottles and takeout containers lay scattered about the room, almost completely obscuring the carpeted floor. More disturbingly,

bandages and towels stained with dark crimson splotches were strewn about. It was clear to Adora now why their room was in such good condition: Catra hadn't been using it for some time. In the center of the room, the bed was unkempt. The sheets and comforter lay wrinkled in a pile at the base of the bed frame, and on top of the bed…

Adora's eyes widened until they felt like they were bulging out of her skull.

Catra lay face down on the bare mattress, her face obscured by a pillow and her hair messily draped over the back of her neck. The only thing she wore was a pair of boxers. The rest of her clothes were haphazardly thrown to one side of the bed: a sports bra here, a black t-shirt there. Adora couldn't help but drink in more of the scene as the pieces started falling together. Her well-muscled body was tense, and quaking slightly. She was grinding back and forth against the pillow held between her legs, and groaning loudly into the one her face was buried into.

Then she noticed the gashes. They were all over her body. Some of them closed, some of them still lazily oozing. There were so many…

"...Catra?" Adora whispered. She was not supposed to see this.

The cat whipped her head around. A mix of embarrassment and fury burned in her eyes. "Get out!" she screeched, loud enough to echo through the house and leave Adora's ears ringing as she slammed the door shut behind her.

An inconsolable Adora turned her back to the door and slid down to the ground, trying to grasp everything she had just seen. Catra was drinking. And cutting. She had been spiraling for a month. And even though she didn't know why, it *had* to be her fault.

"I never should have left," she thought to herself, covering her sobs with one hand and wiping the hot tears now streaming down her face with the other.

Ruin

Chapter Summary

Catra confronts Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C A T R A

Catra's head hurt. Her world spun. Not just from her inebriated state, but also from the fact that she had sat up so fast she slammed her head into the bedframe. In a way, it was a good thing. The pounding pain in her skull gave her something to focus on other than how angry she was at Adora. She had let it fester for a month already, but the new fuel she had to add to the raging inferno was delicious. "Walking in on me grinding a pillow," Catra thought to herself. She added it to her list.

Adora knew they had prior arrangements and chose another roommate anyways. "And a theater major at that," she grumbled to herself.

Adora knew that her foster dad had been Catra's by proxy for the last twelve years, and she didn't even consider taking her along to see him in his final days. She couldn't put into words how neglected it made her feel. A muted voice in the back of her head said, "She wasn't thinking." Catra pushed it away. He was gone, and she'd *never* have the chance to say goodbye. Ever.

Adora knew what she was doing. She was clearly on track to abandon Catra, just like Aunt Weaver had warned her. "She hates me," Catra thought. "All she ever did was humor me." She felt her claws tearing into her body again, but then she stopped herself. The look Adora had given her… it almost looked like concern. "No!" the voice in her head snarled. "She doesn't care about you. Why would she?"

Catra groaned as she slid her blood slickened back across the bare mattress. That hurt too. Everything she did anymore hurt. "Existence is torture," she thought to herself bitterly. If Adora had abandoned her, why not drink herself to sleep every night? Why not cut until she couldn't feel her body? Nothing mattered anymore.

She pushed herself off the bed with a small grunt, then heard something. Her ears perked up. She tried to focus through her pounding headache. Was Adora… crying?

Catra burst into a laughing fit of loud, hoarse cackles. She wasn't quite sure why. Nothing was particularly funny, but she couldn't help laughing anyways. Then, she doubled over and threw up. There was nothing in her system except the liquor she had downed the night before, so her body worked as hard as it could to cough up a few dribbles of clear bile.

She heard Adora get up on the other side of the door. She waited to hear her walk away, but she didn't.

"Catra?" she said, her voice low and muffled through the door. "Can I come in?"

"You already did!" she spat back, pacing over to the door and slamming it open. Adora's eyes were wide, and she had obviously been crying. Catra realized that she was still half naked, but she didn't really care. She moved her arms in a broad, uncoordinated gesture for Adora to walk in. Adora sniffed, then cautiously stepped around the piles of garbage on the floor and gently sat down on the bed.

Catra stayed standing.

"Do you want to, uh…" Adora began, her gaze dropping to Catra's exposed breasts.

"Want to… what?" she retorted. Her sense of decency had disappeared long ago. "Get abandoned by my best friend? Miss my only chance to say goodbye to the man who raised me?"

Recognition flickered in Adora's eyes and she started crying again. God did Catra hate crying.

"Catra," she said, her voice choking up, "I am so, so, so-"

"I don't get you," Catra ranted, the alcohol talking for her. "Do you think you can just come back here like nothing's happened?" She snorted. "Don't talk to me. Go talk to *Glimmer*. She'll listen more than I *ever* will." Adora really was unbelievable.

Adora looked… confused? She looked up at Catra, half formed tears glistening in her eyes. "Who's Glimmer?" she asked. She genuinely didn't seem to know.

"Your *roommate*?" Catra hissed, throwing her hands up dramatically. "Ring a bell?" This blonde really was stupid.

"Catra, you aren't making sense. How drunk are you?" Adora asked. Her red eyes softened with concern. "How much have you *been* drinking?" she said, her eyes hovering over the piles of garbage that had piled up around her.

"Only the normal amount," Catra said sarcastically, her voice hoarse from the bile. She walked over to the nightstand and picked up Adora's roommate assignment letter, which she had crumpled into a ball. She threw it at Adora, who promptly caught it out of the air.

"What's this?" Adora asked, but Catra refused to explain.

"I'm taking a shower," Catra decided aloud, flinging her boxers off in Adora's direction, who let out a surprised squeak. Catra strutted over to the bathroom door, slamming it shut behind her.

The scalding water stung her new mutilations, but she didn't mind. She wondered what was going through Adora's mind right now. "If she didn't know I was a monster before, she does now," Catra thought to herself grimly. A hint of remorse registered in the back of her mind, but yet again she pushed it down.

The shower only lasted a few minutes. Catra didn't take the time to clean herself. Instead, she just sat under the water and stared at the white tiles. It made her head pound a little less. She wondered why she had even wanted to take a shower in the first place.

As she climbed out of the shower, the first thought she had was, “Adora’s still outside.” Then the gravity of everything she had done began to sink in. She saw through the haze of liquor clouding her mind, and realized just how much of a mess she was. How much she was acting like Aunt Weaver. This notion was far too alarming to push down.

Catra wanted to scream. She hovered her claws over her arms, but stopped herself before she could break skin. She could’ve used this month to do anything else, but she had sat and moped, drank, and self mutilated. Instead of consoling Adora, she had cut her off when she needed Catra most. The revelations kept on coming, overwhelming her with a torrent of thoughts and feelings her muddled mind couldn’t fully comprehend. What she did know was that she had royally fucked up.

Catra collapsed on the floor with a loud “thud.” She curled up into a ball and cried out in pain.

“Catra!” Adora yelled through the door. She could hear her heavy footsteps running over to it, and in an instant she had pulled it open to find a soaked Catra curled up on the bathroom floor, crying silently.

Words couldn’t do justice to the heartbroken look on Adora’s face as she gazed down at the drunken wreck that was Catra. She cradled the shivering girl in her arms, desperately whispering whatever she could think of to comfort the distressed cat and soaking herself in the process. Catra let herself cry. Part of her didn’t want to be comforted by Adora, not after she’d been such a consistently awful friend. But the other part of her didn’t want Adora to let go. Ever.

A fantasy ran through her drunken mind. It was a perfect, sunny day. The morning light had just pierced through the blinds of their room, forming a perfect pool of sunlight at the foot of the bed, right where Catra was waking up. She slowly stretched and yawned. Adora sat upright, watching her contentedly.

“Why are you still down there?” she said, a warm smile spreading across her face. Her eyes glowed with warmth. “Climb in and cuddle with me.” She pulled down the sheet a little, revealing her muscular, tan body.

Catra purred and happily obliged. Adora was so warm…

Then, she snapped back to the brutal reality she had forced upon them both.

She looked up at Adora’s face. Even with tear stains, bags under her eyes, and unkempt hair, she looked heavenly. Catra let out a silent sigh. The blonde was still trying to calm Catra down, shushing her and murmuring calming words. Whatever was left of her anger melted away.

“You’re such an idiot,” Catra thought hazily. “My idiot.”

She leaned up and, closing her eyes, gently pressed her lips against Adora’s.

Chapter End Notes

Ha 6 chapters into my "college au" and we aren't even at college yet.
Fml.

Playing Catch-up

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra get on the same page

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A D O R A

Adora sat on the bare mattress, staring at the now unfurled paper that Catra had thrown at her. It just didn't make sense. They had both sent in their roommate request forms, why weren't they put together? She just couldn't piece it together.

She sighed and sat back on the bed, sitting up again when she remembered the blood stained onto the mattress. Adora had always known Catra had darkness in her: it was part of why their relationship worked so well. Adora's optimism kept Catra's mood in check, and vice versa. It was just so hard to believe that after two months away Catra could spiral down *this* far.

Adora took a moment to clear her mind. Dwelling on the past wouldn't do any good. Instead, she focused on the gentle pitter patter of the shower water, muffled through the bathroom door. She imagined it falling softly on Catra's back, rolling down her body…

She'd be lying to herself if she said Catra's lack of clothes hadn't distracted her at least a little. Living in the same room for 12 years they had seen one another naked more times than she could count, but Catra was never as confident as she had just been. And sure, it was only because she was drunk, but it was still sexy. Adora imagined her standing there with her supple breasts exposed, one hip cockily thrown to the side, her hands on her waist. Then, the ease with which she flung her boxers off as she walked away… Adora forgot sometimes that Catra had a penis, but

it had never bothered her. It was just another part of what made Catra herself, and that was beautiful.

"Snap out of it Adora!" her mind reminded her. "She was drunk. She wasn't being an exhibitionist on purpose." She never wanted to take advantage of Catra like she had at the party, and even thinking about her while she was drunk felt the same. But at the same time, she couldn't stop her mind from wandering to the marks of self harm coating her so thoroughly, contrasting her lithe, muscled figure… she managed to make them sexy, too.

Then, she heard a loud "thud" come from the bathroom, followed by a whimper of pain. Adora's heart nearly pounded out of her chest. "I'm such an idiot," she thought to herself. She had let Catra out of her sight when she was drunk off her ass, and now she'd hurt herself. "Catra?" she called out, leaping off the bed and running to the bathroom door.

She was curled up in a pool of water outside the shower, sobbing quietly. Something in Adora broke a little. It made her upset seeing Catra angry at her, sure, but her lying utterly miserable, sobbing alone on the bathroom floor struck a new chord. She immediately dropped to the ground and embraced the shivering girl.

"Shh, shh, it's okay, everything will be okay," she whispered, unknowing of whether or not she was helping, or if Catra could even really hear her. Her clothes were getting soaked, but she didn't really care. All that mattered was calming Catra down.

As Catra snuggled up against her, Adora couldn't help but notice how their bodies were pressed together, the way her hips trembled a little with each muted sob. She ran a hand over Catra's wet hair, slicked down to her wet back. She seemed to be calming down a bit, and Adora's heartbeat gradually slowed.

As her breathing returned to normal, Catra shifted around until she was looking up at Adora. Her eyes were so soft…

Then, Catra leaned in and kissed her.

Adora would've liked to refuse, to push Catra away and wait until she was sober. But she couldn't. Her mind had gone haywire, and whatever thoughts she might've had evaporated away in an instant.

It was a gentle kiss. Catra's lips were so soft. Adora could feel her cheeks flush a little as Catra pushed her face into Adora's, the bridges of their noses rubbing against each other. She felt Catra's fingers gently tangle into her hair, pulling her in even closer. Catra pressed her body up against Adora even harder, slipping her tongue into Adora's mouth. She felt a muted throbbing between her legs. Something in Adora's head told her to stop. This wasn't fair for Catra. It was too much like that night.

Adora pushed back gently. "Catra," she muttered, her mouth still full of Catra's tongue. She continued kissing and pressed back even harder.

"Catra!" Adora said again, pulling back a little more forcefully. The cat gazed up at Adora, her eyes dulling a little. She whispered something to herself and curled up in a ball again.

"What did you say?" Adora asked gently, stroking her hair again.

"Stay," Catra whispered. Adora's heart broke a little.

"Of course," she whispered back. Catra's eyelids drooped, then fully closed. From the soft sounds of her breaths Adora could tell she had fallen asleep.

Adora really didn't want to stand and risk waking up Catra, but she was still sitting in a pool of cold shower water on the bathroom floor. Slowly, she shuffled into an upright position and, cradling Catra in her arms, walked into their room.

She dried Catra off with a clean towel, and slipped a loose sweatshirt over her. Then, she tucked her into bed. Adora

wondered how long it had been since she had last slept. Her face seemed so much more peaceful…

Adora let out a heavy sigh. She sat down at the foot of the bed, her mind swirling from the information overload she had just received. Catra was not doing well. She was drinking and self harming. They hadn't been assigned as roommates either. They had to be at Brightmoon for move in tomorrow, and neither of them had anything packed. And Catra *couldn't* pack because she had passed out.

Her stomach growled. Adora was still hungry. She got up after a minute and started walking downstairs to the kitchen. "And she kissed me," she added, butterflies flourishing in her belly.

Digging around the kitchen proved futile. It looked like Catra had eaten everything in the house while she was away, so Adora ended up ordering a pizza instead. With buffalo wings. They were Catra's favorite.

In the meantime, she started packing. Her father had bought a big stack of unfolded cardboard boxes for them to pack with months ago. Catra was still sound asleep, so Adora figured there was no way she'd wake up. Little by little, Adora transferred both of their wardrobes into the boxes, then started working on what she knew Catra would want. Definitely her ukulele and laptop. The pictures on her walls, and the little plush lion she'd slept with since they were kids. She looked up at the drawing above the windowsill. It didn't feel right taking it down after all this time. She'd have to ask Catra what they wanted to do with it when she woke up.

The pizza arrived and Adora scarfed down half of it, leaving the rest and the wings for when Catra woke up. In the middle of her meal, she got a phone call from the same man she had spoken to the morning prior. He reiterated how Adora could claim the insurance money from her father's death and how to access his old accounts. It was strange knowing that, for the foreseeable future, money wouldn't be an obstacle for her. She lived frugally,

and despite her newfound wealth she wasn't planning on changing that any time soon.

For the rest of the day, Adora packed the rest of what they would need. And even if she had forgotten anything, the house was only an hour and a half away from campus.

When all that was done, she sat down on the couch and relaxed for the first time she could remember. Lying back and closing her eyes, she started to think about Catra. What she could do to help her out, and how to stay in touch even though they wouldn't be living together anymore. That presented a whole host of problems. If Adora wasn't around to make sure she was doing okay every day, Catra might relapse. "She'll have to quit first," Adora thought to herself grimly. She'd have to talk with whoever Catra's roommate was, assuming they were a decent person.

The next semester was only a few months away. If they could make it to the winter, they could request a room swap and start living together again. Everything would go back to normal.

"What does normal even *look* like now?" Adora thought to herself. She couldn't come up with an answer. Too much had changed, mostly for the worse. "But she did kiss me," Adora's mind reminded her. Even if she had been drunk, maybe, just maybe, Adora's feelings were mutual. Her heart fluttered like a caged bird. It had been so hard to resist Catra's advances, but she didn't want to take advantage of her again. She would never forgive herself. But if she had…

Adora was so deep in thought she almost missed the soft thumps of Catra's feet on the stairs. She turned her head and saw her walking down slowly, dragging one finger along the railing. She either hadn't noticed Adora yet, or she was ignoring her.

As she walked into the kitchen, Adora said, "Hey Catra."

"Hi," was all Catra responded with, not quite meeting Adora's eyes. She was shocked. Catra had always greeted her with "Hey

Adora," ever since they had first met, and the plain "hi" really caught Adora off guard.

"Catra…" she began. Adora didn't even know where to start. "How much do you remember?"

Catra didn't respond for a minute as she pulled out a paper plate and threw the wings on it. In the end she just muttered, "thanks," still not meeting Adora's eyes. She plopped herself down on the couch across from her.

Adora let her eat for a minute. Then two. When it became clear she didn't have any intention of responding, Adora spoke up again, "Catra, there are some things we need to talk about. I'm not mad at you, I promise. I just want to make sure we're on the same page."

She looked up from the wings with a dejected gaze at Adora. There were little smears of wing sauce at the corners of her mouth. "On the same page about what?" she asked. "How much of an awful person I am? That I destroyed your guest room? Maybe the fact that I'm binge drinking?"

"Catra…" Adora said. She wasn't being fair to herself.

She continued, cutting Adora off. Her eyes were a little more fiery now. "Or maybe you wanted to talk about these?" she said, pulling her sleeve up to reveal the rows of lacerations. "Or…" she stopped herself and blushed, looking away again.

"She does remember," Adora thought to herself. She walked over to Catra. She still wouldn't meet Adora's eyes.

Adora kneeled down and took Catra's hands in hers. "Catra," she began, "You aren't an awful person. I don't hate you, and I will never hate you." She met Adora's gaze again, the purest relief shining in her eyes. "How long has it been going on?" Adora asked.

“A month,” Catra choked out. Adora moved in to hug her. She tensed up at first, but eventually accepted it. The pair started tearing up.

“I am so sorry. I left you here. I should’ve brought you with me. I wasn’t thinking, I never knew this would happen, I-”

Catra cut her off. “I’m sorry too,” she whispered in Adora’s ear. “I cut myself off when you… when *we* needed each other most.”

They stayed in silent embrace for what felt like hours, desperately trying to come up with the words to describe what they were feeling, both failing.

“Hey Adora?” Catra asked, pulling away from the hug and wrapping her arms around herself. Her voice cracked as she said it and tears streamed down her cheeks.

“What?” Adora asked softly, sitting down on the couch next to Catra. She seemed so small.

Looking up at her, Catra whispered, “I don’t want to be like this.” She closed her eyes and more tears rolled down each side of her face. “I don’t want to drink. I don’t want to hurt myself. But I don’t know how to stop,” she pleaded.

Adora pulled Catra into her much like she had done on the bathroom floor and hugged her. “I know you don’t,” Adora said, secretly overjoyed that she wanted to stop. “And I’ll help you. I’ll get you help. We’ll get through this,” she added.

“Thanks,” Catra sniffed, seeming a little more hopeful.

A minute passed. Now it was Adora’s turn.

“Catra?’ she asked. The girl unburied her head from Adora’s chest and looked at her expectantly.

“How much do you remember?” Adora felt like she could hear a pin drop in the living room. Catra held her gaze for a moment.

She looked like a deer in headlights.

“Everything,” was her eventual response. Her eyes shined and her face turned tomato red.

Another moment passed.

“How much of it do you regret?” Adora asked. She needed to hear this, even if it broke her heart.

“Nothing,” Catra responded, looking almost as afraid as Adora felt.

Chapter End Notes

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Spicy wings

Chapter Summary

Catra *really* liked those wings.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C A T R A

As the cat gazed into Adora's eyes, she saw something she didn't expect. Fear. Anxiety. For her entire life she had planned on taking her feelings for Adora to the grave. But that glimmer of… of *something* in Adora's eyes emboldened her. "Gay panic?" a smug voice in her head suggested. Whatever it was, it convinced Catra to speak the truth.

"Nothing," her body breathed out. She didn't regret kissing Adora at all. It wasn't even a question, really. And as she braced herself for the cold talons of disgust, or rejection, or dismissal to dig into her, something strange happened. Adora leaned down and kissed her. And Catra's world exploded.

Catra wrapped her hands around Adora's back, locking them into the embrace. Her claws slid out just enough to poke Adora's back a little, as if warning her not to let go. Adora pushed her face forwards, sealing their lips together. Catra's tongue pushed its way into her mouth, flitting around quickly as if trying to memorize every fleeting detail.

The two had kissed before, but never like this. This wasn't a sloppy, drunken afterthought. This was a proper lovers embrace. Both of them were fully conscious, fully aware of the ramifications it had for their future. There was no backing down now. Catra was almost swept away in the rush of emotions coursing through her head. The loss and hurt were still within both of them, but they were joined now by a new feeling: burning hot desire.

Love. Catra had never truly understood what love meant, beyond the vague memory of her parents as a child. Now, it was unmistakable. She knew, and she'd never be able to forget. The utter need with which their bodies were glued together, the throbbing and pulsing of her body demanding more, the absolute necessity to be intertwined into one and never separate. She thought back and remembered the fleeting glances she'd catch Adora giving her all throughout their childhood. That was love, too. She just hadn't known it then. Everything in the world made sense, and nothing mattered except staying in this embrace for as long as she possibly could.

Adora's hands slowly moved up and down Catra's sides, gently tracing the seams of her sweatshirt. She shivered a little, still desperately clinging to Adora's back. Catra craned her head back and let out a low moan as Adora broke off and started kissing across her jaw line.

Catra probably would've been unsettled by the way her body responded to Adora's if it didn't feel so good. She let out another moan, louder this time. Then she noticed her hips grinding against Adora's lap. How long had she been grinding her hips? Catra didn't know, but she also didn't want to stop.

"How long?" Adora murmured, her voice muted by Catra's skin.

"So long… since kindergarten," Catra cried between desperate gasps for air, her voice breaking a little. Adora let out a long, shuddering sigh. She slipped her hands under Catra's sweater, gently sliding across her scarred and aching chest. She let out a gasp of pain as Adora touched one that was still sore.

Adora sat up at once, her body rigid. "Are you okay?" she asked, concern flaring in her eyes.

"I'm fine, don't stop," Catra moaned into Adora's chest. She smiled and slid her hands back underneath the sweatshirt, her finger fumbling and eventually finding the catch on the back of Catra's bra. Her heart leapt into her throat as Adora unfastened it, then

gently tugged her sweatshirt over her head and threw it over the couch.

Adora stopped in her tracks and stared at Catra's nude body. Urgent desire lit her face. "You're so beautiful," she breathed. Then, before she could even react, Adora scooped Catra up into her arms. She let out a surprised squeak as Adora started towards the stairs, showering her in kisses the entire way.

Catra was in heaven. Scratch that, she was above heaven. She had fantasized about this moment for years, and now it was actually happening. She couldn't help but tremble with anticipation as Adora opened the door to their bedroom, then kicked it shut as if it were just an afterthought. She pinned the now topless Catra to the middle of the bed. Adora seemed so much bigger than her…

Catra watched as Adora lowered her head down and planted a gentle kiss on a particularly large cut just above her left breast. Then, she kissed a cut on her breast. Adora kissed every scar she had carved into her body and Catra sat there and let her.

"I'll fix you," Adora whispered into her ear. She shuddered.

Catra hated that she had done this to herself. Letting out a tiny whimpering moan as Adora kissed the last one, Adora peeled her shirt off to reveal her well muscled figure underneath. Catra couldn't do anything but stare as she climbed back onto the bed, her head resting gently on Catra's exposed belly. She could smell Adora's slightly sweat moistened skin, the faintest hint of that citrusy soap she loved buried beneath it.

"Catra…" Adora said quietly, "I want you *so* bad. But I don't want to do anything you're uncomfortable with. Okay?" she asked, eyes glistening with concern.

Catra gulped and nodded.

"How do you want to do this?" she asked, gently running her fingers across Catra's belly. She shivered.

Catra sat up slowly. She wished more than anything that she hadn't been born limited by her anatomy. But she wouldn't let her self pity drown out this moment. She let her hands and mouth caress all over Adora's body, leaving goosebumps in their wake. Up and down her abs, her shoulders, the small of her back. She cupped her hands under Adora's breasts and felt their weight. She teased her hard nipples with little licks and nibbles. Catra wanted to be everywhere at once, and from the sound of Adora's increasingly loud moans, so did she. As she made her way back down Adora's body, she unfastened the drawstring of her sweats with her teeth. Then, she slid her fingers even further down, eliciting a long, shuddering breath from Adora. Catra felt Adora's slick pussy for the first time. It was perfect. So warm and inviting…

Slowly, she slid Adora's sweats down and threw them behind her onto the increasingly tall pile of clothes at the foot of the bed. Her panties were soaked through, and Adora kicked those off too. "I did this," Catra thought with satisfaction, looking down at Adora's throbbing, drenched pussy. She placed her fingers over Adora's folds, and rubbed them around in the slick wetness covering her. Adora let out a long moan. "Please Catra," she begged, "I need you inside me, please Catra…"

Catra just sat there and smirked, rubbing Adora's lips even more. Then, she took two of her fingers that were drenched in Adora's fluids and stuck them in her mouth. She closed her eyes and whispered, "you taste divine," in one long, shuddering breath. "Now a little bit of you will always be with me," she said seductively. Adora's eyes nearly bulged out of her head. Catra had wanted to say that for *so* long. She ran her fingers back down to Adora's mons, teasing her sticky labia.

Adora let out a whine and continued begging Catra to do something, anything to pleasure her. Catra laid down just below Adora, her head pressed between her muscular thighs, and took a deep breath. It was getting hard to hold *herself* back, so Catra couldn't imagine how Adora was feeling. She opened her mouth against Adora's dripping pussy, and touched the tip of her tongue

to one of her folds. Adora's body quivered a little and she let out a long, moaning gasp as Catra slid her tongue between them and gently lapped away at her. From the noises Adora was making, Catra would've thought she was being tortured, but her body betrayed her. She was a quivering, shaking, begging mess. But she was *Catra's* mess.

Catra forcefully pressed her mouth up against Adora's mons, continuing her tongue movements as she tried to suck out Adora's soul. After a few minutes of Catra spelling out the alphabet, both of their names front-to-back, and pretty much everything else her clouded mind could think of, she slowly ran her tongue up to Adora's swollen clit. She had rimmed around it a few times, but Catra had yet to stroke it, and Adora sounded like she was begging with all her being for release.

Taking a deep breath through her nostrils, Catra mentally prepared herself for the home stretch. Her tongue was exhausted. She gently licked the very base of Adora's clit, and the blonde let out a wail of pleasure. Her entire body tensed up for a moment, and Catra thought that might've been enough to send her over the edge. But it wasn't. Adora was back to begging seconds later, and Catra went back down, teasing her clit even more, even faster, until Adora's entire body tensed up and she let out a long, guttural moan that Catra never would've thought Adora's mouth could produce. She laid back on the bed, panting, seemingly lost to the world. Catra sat up and smiled gently, watching Adora slowly come back to reality.

"That, you…" Adora mumbled as she slowly found her words. She eventually settled on "you're amazing," before pulling Catra back down into another hug.

"Is that it?" Adora asked after a few minutes of collecting herself. She had sorrow in her eyes.

"What do you mean?" Catra asked, narrowing her eyes. Was Adora really unsatisfied after all that?

Adora's eyes widened. "Nonono, not like that, I just… you made me feel so fucking good Catra. I want to pleasure you, too. It doesn't seem fair," she said, sorrow in her eyes.

Catra's heart sank. "Oh," she replied.

The two sat in silent solitude for a moment. Catra was still wearing her shorts, her erection just fading.

"Is it okay if I try?" Adora asked gently, looking to Catra for approval.

She nodded silently.

"Tell me if you want me to stop," Adora said, pulling Catra back in for another kiss. This one was different, though. Instead of the heat of passion, this one was reminiscent of the sorrow two heartbroken lovers would share before departing for the last time, mourning all that would never be. As Adora moved to slide her shorts off, Catra gripped her arm. "Stop," she whispered, pushing Adora away and curling up into a ball.

Adora let out a sigh and hugged the distressed cat as hard as she could. "I'm so sorry," she whispered.

"S'not your fault," Catra said back dejectedly. "It's just what I have to live with."

Adora sighed again, then perked up. She broke away from the hug and leapt off the bed. She squatted down and dug around the underside of her bed for… something.

"What?" Catra said, a little less solemn. *Something* had Adora more animated, and she wanted to know what it was.

Adora looked a little embarrassed as she pulled a big shoebox out from under the bed and placed it on the sheets. She flipped the lid off, revealing a stack of… old porn magazines?

Catra couldn't help but burst into laughter. "What are you, a grandma? You know the internet exists, right?" she teased.

Adora's face flushed cherry red. "Yes! Shut up! I'm trying to help you!" she said, digging around in the box until she pulled out a big, white vibrator. "Aha!" she proclaimed, holding it up like a hero might hold a sword.

Catra smiled. "Dork," she thought to herself.

Lowering her arm, Adora said with a hopeful look, "I could use this. You can close your eyes and keep your underwear on, if you want."

"I want to marry this woman," was the only thought Catra could conjure up. She thought about it for a moment, eventually responding with a hopeful "Sure, we can try it." Adora's face lit up with excitement.

"Alright, lay back on the bed," she said. Catra's belly fluttered a little when Adora told her what to do, and happily obliged.

She rested her head on the pillow and closed her eyes. Nothing happened for a minute. The anticipation was making Catra harder again. Then, right as she was about to ask Adora what was going on, she heard a low hum. Tensing up her body, Catra braced herself for however awful she'd feel when the rubber bulb pressed up against her. But much to her surprise, she didn't feel awful. The vibrator felt… nice.

Catra let out a small sigh as she let her body relax. This really didn't feel bad at all. Soon, she was moaning and squirming and panting just like Adora had been minutes earlier. And quicker than she expected, she came to a climax. Her body simultaneously soared into the clouds and melted into a puddle, and Adora held her the entire time, tears of joy in the corners of her eyes. When she eventually came back to her senses, she looked up at Adora and wondered how they had taken so long to admit their love for each other.

“Thanks,” Catra whispered into Adora’s ear, snuggling up closer to her. “I don’t want to go pack, I just want to snuggle,” she complained.

“I, uh, forgot to mention. I already did. For both of us,” Adora said back. “We can stay like this as long as you want.”

Catra sighed lightly. She truly felt happy for the first time in months. “Thanks for the wings, too. Spicy. They’re my favorite,” she said.

All Adora whispered back was, “I know.”

Chapter End Notes

AAAA

Rode the six hundred

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora depart

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Their evening consisted of a few hours of cuddling, then reheating what was left of the pizza and digging around the pantry until they found some chips and salsa that Catra hadn't gotten to. Both would've loved to go down on each other again, but agreed that they were far too exhausted, physically and emotionally. "We'll do it again another day," Adora promised.

"So, does that mean we're dating?" Catra asked, a little too hopefully.

Adora thought for a moment, then responded, "I think so," with a wide grin.

They smiled, then shared another hug.

Adora broke off with a frown. "I almost forgot, I have to check my dad's accounts and move money over. I'll be back in a couple minutes," she promised, planting a kiss on Catra's forehead.

Catra just sighed as she watched Adora walk into the other room. She felt so cold without Adora's warmth next to her. "It's been 8 hours," her brain reminded her. "You can't be this dependent on her already." But hadn't she been for the last twelve years?

As she mused about Adora alone on the couch, she heard Adora's distressed voice calling her from the room over.

Catra jumped up and ran into the room, and saw Adora staring at the computer screen. She turned to look at the cat. "There's a

section dedicated to you," she said, happy tears glistening in her eyes.

She got up and let Catra sit down at the computer, clicking on the section titled, "Catra's Inheritance." A wall of text appeared, along with a long routing number and password.

Catra, my daughter, I can't imagine how heartbroken you must be. You've already lost two of your parents and although legally I have never been your father, for these past twelve years that is very much what I've become. I have always known this in my heart, and I hope you have known it in yours. When I received my diagnosis, Adora rushed to see me, unknowing of how much time I would have left. She still believes I can pull through, but I feel the dreadful aching in my body every day reminding me that no matter how hard I fight, I won't. Adora didn't bring you with her, but please don't hold this against her. She was in shock, as I'm sure you were at the time. I've been told time and time again that each day may be my last, and so although Adora has begged and pleaded to retrieve you and reunite our family one last time, I've denied her. I am utterly terrified of dying alone, surrounded by meaningless beeps and sterile walls and none of the people whom I love. So, here I am, writing this letter. It's so much less than what you deserve, even if you don't realize that now, and I am sorry for this with my entire being. I can't express how upset it makes me, and I'm sure you're upset as well, as is within your right.

For years after my husband died I tried to find meaning in my work. I never did. It was merely a distraction from my grief, and a poor one at that. And then, I found meaning in my daughters. I try to think of you both only for brief moments because the pain of knowing that I'm leaving you behind is almost too much to bear, much like I'm sure my husband would've felt if he'd had time for reflection all those years ago. I've waited a month to write this, but Adora's distress has spurred me to action. She won't tell me exactly what's going on, but I know it has to be between you

both, and I know it must be serious. She's lost her light, the light that only you've ever been able to provide her. I don't know where you are, nor what's happened between the two of you, but I can guarantee you this. Adora loves you more than you know, more than you may ever know, and I know that you love her too. I've seen the glances, the way you laugh when you're around her, the utter joy you bring each other by existing in the same room. Don't live in denial. Please take care of each other when I'm gone. I know that if you do, everything will turn out alright. I promise.

Now onto the rest. I've left you a hefty chunk of my finances for your inheritance, enough to cover your tuition and living expenses for the coming years of school. I've also expedited the process of transferring you onto my healthcare plan, which should almost entirely cover any corrective surgeries you get in the next five years. I know how much you've hated your body, and I'm sorry that I was never able to do this in my lifetime. If you want it, this insurance will allow you to undergo whichever treatments you desire at little to no cost to yourself.

You're a beautiful young woman with your entire life ahead of you. Treat each other well. I love you.

Halfway through the first paragraph, Catra began to cry. Adora silently hugged her, burying her face in Catra's shoulder. "What did it say?" she whispered. Catra didn't respond. All she did was savor the feeling of Adora's arms around her and continue to weep.

When the accounts had all been transferred, both of them went upstairs to share their old bed one last time. Neither Adora nor Catra said it aloud, but both were thinking about it. Adora stripped down and climbed in, Catra followed suit. It didn't seem proper to sleep at the foot of the bed anymore. Too much had changed. Catra quickly fell asleep in Adora's warm embrace.

All too soon, it was morning. The overcast sky shone dim light through the half-closed blinds, and the sound of Adora's alarm

woke both of them up. They promptly got dressed and packed the car with boxes, each labeled in Adora's handwriting.

As Catra went back upstairs to say a final farewell to their barren room, she remembered the crayon drawing taped above the window. She retrieved a stepladder from the closet and gently peeled away the tape holding it to the wall. Then, she went back downstairs and found Adora lounging on the couch, deep in thought.

"Hey Adora?" Catra asked, holding the fading lion drawing in her hands. The marks from the tape that had hung it up for all those years were notably whiter than the yellowing paper. "You should take this." she said, holding out the paper.

Adora looked at her with alarm. "Catra, it's yours. You made it. I know how much it means to you."

It was true. The worn paper did mean a lot to Catra. Some part of her attributed the memory of her parents to that drawing. Maybe, she thought, when she made it all those years ago she remembered a bit more of them. Now there were no memories left. All she had was the lion.

"No," she said firmly, pressing it into Adora's hands. "You take it. I don't need it."

Adora gave her one of those crinkly eye smiles Catra couldn't say no to. "How about," she said, gently pushing back to Catra, "next semester when we're sharing a dorm you give it to me."

"Okay," Catra whispered. That damn smile.

When the car was all packed up, they got inside and took one last look at the house they'd both grown up in. Catra could almost pretend like it was the first time she had come over to Adora's. The pale blue paint and white window trim were exactly the same, the dark slate roof contrasting against the bleak gray sky. But some things were different, too. The lawn had grown untamed and wild in her father's absence. There were no toys strewn about

the lawn, nor was the clothesline hung, it's colorful shirts and pants blowing in the breeze. The wind seemed stale and lifeless.

“We’ll be back over breaks,” Adora said aloud, as if reassuring herself. “This isn’t goodbye.”

What she said might’ve been true, but it didn’t feel that way.

As they drove away, both women were silent as they mused over what the future held.

“So…” Adora said after a moment, “how are you feeling?”

Catra looked out the window. “Good,” she replied. In reality, her thoughts were charged with nervous energy, not unlike the storm brewing above them. Catra didn’t know who she would be living with for the foreseeable future. Even though she knew how Adora felt about her, she was still worried that she might abandon her. Her thoughts consumed her, growing like an infection festering in diseased flesh. If it had been a few days earlier, she would’ve cut herself. But she didn’t, because it wasn’t.

Adora placed her hand on Catra’s thigh. She looked over at the obviously distressed Catra with a worried expression. “Hey,” she said, as Catra turned her head to face Adora, “everything’s going to work out. I promise. Soon, you’ll be playing ukulele for me and watching my hockey games again.”

Adora’s friendly smile almost convinced her. Almost.

Chapter End Notes

> I said this in another note too but jfc, in my college au we're only actually getting to college at chapter ten.

Before the Storm

Chapter Summary

Adora meets Bow & Glimmer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A D O R A

Hours later, the car reached its destination: Brightmoon University. She had waited ages for this moment, and it was finally here. The big blue and purple lettering above the gate, the perfectly maintained lawn, the tall brick buildings, their tops just barely visible amidst the oak canopy shading the campus. Adora heard Catra sit up and yawn beside her. She had fallen asleep miles ago. Now, her ears perked up as she saw the big blue and purple lettering adorning the gates to the university.

"Here we are," Catra muttered, arching her back and lifting her arms in a big stretch. "Is it everything you thought it'd be?" she said, a bit sarcastically.

"It is," Adora whispered to herself, completely missing the edge to Catra's voice. She parked the car close to her dorm and got out. "Here it is, Etheria Hall," she said wondrously. The dorms at Brightmoon University were spread across campus. Etheria was the so-called honors dorm, set on one side of the great lawn. Catra was dorming in Fright Hall, set on the exact opposite end.

As they got out of the car, Adora noticed just how many people were crowded around the dorm, bringing in big boxes, luggage, chairs, tvs, and so much more. It was a little stressful for her to be around so many people, so she could only imagine how Catra felt right now. By the look on her face, it was clear she wasn't enjoying the mob. But they had to unload some time. Grabbing a

box labeled *Adora* from her trunk, Adora said, “Come on, they aren’t gonna clear a path for us. We just have to go.”

Catra groaned in frustration, gritted her teeth, and grabbed a box, wading through the crowd of people after Adora. The elevators were completely occupied, so Adora decided to take the stairs, eliciting another groan from Catra, who stomped up after her. Adora walked down the long hall, bumping into people left and right. Looking back at Catra, she looked like she wanted to die of embarrassment. Suppressing a laugh, Adora realized she was standing in front of her room. *Her* room. Number 26. The door was already propped open, and it sounded like there was someone inside. She glanced back at Catra, then took a deep breath and pushed her way inside.

Before her eyes could even get a glimpse of the room, an explosion of glittery confetti hit her face. “Happy move in!” two cheery voices shouted from inside the room. Batting the confetti from her face and spitting a few pieces out of her mouth, she surveyed her attackers. A girl with pink and purple hair, presumably another freshman, and a slightly taller boy with side-shaved hair.

“Hi!” Adora squeaked, surprised and a little flustered by the explosive introduction. Catra stood behind her, trying to hold back her growing irritation.

“Nice to meet you!” the girl said. “I’m Glimmer, but I’m sure you already know that. This is my boyfriend Bow!” The boy, Bow, waved sheepishly.

Bow took a little step forward and started talking. “Sorry if it flustered you a little, but I had this confetti popper that one of my dads gave me, and I knew I had to use it *sometime* today, so…”

Bow began telling a long story about exactly how he had come to the conclusion that he should use the confetti right now. Adora laughed to herself. He seemed really considerate, genuinely worried about upsetting her over something as small as confetti.

She immediately understood why Glimmer would be interested in him.

“Bow!” Glimmer complained, “I want to talk to *my* roommate, you can explain later!” Her tone suggested she was mad, but she had laughter sparkling in her eyes.

Turning back to face Adora, she smiled and said, “It’s so nice to meet you! Do you need help unloading stuff? I know those stairs are awful,” she said.

Adora started to say, “that would be great,” only to be interrupted by Catra.

“Actually,” she butted in, “I was already helping Adora. See?” she said, holding up the box she had carried up.

“Catra, it wouldn’t hurt to have more help you know,” Adora said to her. She wasn’t sure why Catra was so irritated: they were only offering to help.

“Come on, follow me!” Adora said happily. She marched out of the room, Glimmer and Bow in tow. Catra stood in the dorm for another minute, eventually trailing behind the three.

“What’s her issue?” Glimmer whispered to Adora. She wasn’t going to get into this now.

“It’s complicated,” Adora said, letting out a long sigh. That sigh said more than she could ever hope to explain about their relationship.

After a few loads of boxes, and the three exchanging some basic information about themselves, Adora said goodbye to go and help unload Catra’s things. “I’ll be back this afternoon!” Adora said, shutting the door behind her. Catra stood outside, fuming.

“What was all that about?” Catra said flatly.

“What do you mean? I was talking to my roommate and her boyfriend. What are you so mad about?” Adora asked.

“You didn’t even bother to introduce me,” Catra said, her eyes darkening with anger.

“You were getting pissy! I didn’t want you to start off on the wrong foot with them,” Adora defended.

“No,” Catra asserted. “Here’s what happened. You walked into your dorm. Your roommate’s boyfriend Bow was there, and she introduced him. I was standing outside and you didn't even bother to introduce me. Do you know how awkward I felt?” Catra said. She was furious, and her eyes glistened with hurt.

Adora’s heart sank. When she put it that way, she completely understood why Catra had been so mad at her. She opened her mouth, but no words came out.

“I asked you if we were dating yesterday and you said yes. So which is it? Yes or no? Because if you aren’t even gonna introduce me as your girlfriend, then why are we *together* at all?” Catra spat, making little air quotes around the word together.

Adora started talking again. “Catra, please, just let me-”

“No,” Catra interrupted. “I’m going to unpack. Alone. I need time to think.” she said, tears in the corners of her eyes. “Maybe you should think about us, too.” With that, she whipped around and barreled down the hallway, knocking everyone out of her way as she ran.

“Catra!” Adora called, but it was too late. The cat was already gone.

Adora’s head spun. “What just happened?” she thought to herself. She would’ve started crying if she hadn’t been so dazed by the flurry of words that Catra threw at her.

She turned her back to the wall, pressing hard against it, and took a deep breath in. She couldn't cry now. She had cried enough in the past month, and all her new peers stood around her, watching, silently judging. She collected herself and, turning around, opened the door to her dorm again.

Glimmer and Bow stared at her. They had heard everything. And clearly by the looks on their faces, Adora was not holding together well.

"Are you okay?" Bow whispered to her. He stepped forward to give her a hug, and Adora accepted it gratefully.

"I don't know," she whispered.

"Here, why don't you sit down?" Glimmer suggested, pulling over a half-constructed IKEA chair.

She sat down.

"So…" Bow said awkwardly, "Is she your girlfriend?"

Adora didn't respond for a moment. "Yes. No. I don't know," she whispered. "Her name is Catra. We've been best friends for as long as I can remember, and lately things have just been so complicated. I'm just not sure what the word is for us anymore." Adora took another breath. She hadn't realized it, but she'd been holding it while she explained. Tears started rolling down her cheeks. "I just want us to get along," she said quietly.

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other, then back at Adora. Without saying a word, they leaned down and gave her a group hug. "It's alright," Glimmer said, but those words gave Adora no comfort.

"No, it isn't, but I can fix this." Adora said, standing up and brushing her tears away. "I'll be back. Maybe a little later than this afternoon, but I will be." She tried to put on a brave face.

“Good luck!” Glimmer told her with a smile, and Bow gave her an encouraging wave.

Adora ran back to her car as fast as she could, dodging and weaving between people the best she could, getting a lot of dirty looks in the process. When she finally made it back to the car, she stopped, completely out of breath. Everything was gone. Catra had taken it already.

“Nonononono,” she whispered to herself, panting from the effort of running down all those stairs. Her mind was threatening a breakdown at any moment, so she headed to the only place she knew Catra might be: Fright Hall.

She sprinted across the great lawn in a blind panic, trying to remember desperately what Catra’s room number was. She had to be there. There was no way she was unpacked already. What was that number? Then, abruptly, she stopped. She couldn’t remember. She had never even known in the first place: Catra didn’t tell her. Should she even keep going to Fright Hall? Catra didn’t want to see her right now anyways.

Adora winced. She had hurt Catra. Again. And now, she couldn’t even explain herself. She sat down in the middle of the lawn and called Catra. The phone rang for a minute, then went to voicemail.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck,” Adora breathed, redialing Catra as soon as her voicemail started playing. It didn’t even ring this time. It went straight to voicemail.

Adora collapsed to her knees. She wanted to cry, but she was out of tears. This was supposed to be a good day. She pulled out her phone and dialed Catra again.

Straight to voicemail.

She buried her head in her hands. A little part of her felt like it was dying. She had *just* got Catra back, and now she was gone again. And even though a part of her knew that it was a small

campus, that she would find Catra eventually, what if she didn't want to be found?

She walked back to her dorm, head hung low, defeated.

She could hear Bow and Glimmer through the door. Adora anguished over having to talk about how awful she felt, to feel their patronizing gazes as she moped. But as she opened the door, she was shocked to discover that they had set up everything for her. The polaroid photos, the hockey equipment, her posters, her bedsheets, everything.

Bow stared at the floor. Glimmer met Adora's eyes. "We felt like you could use a little help," she said warmly.

Words escaped Adora. She knew that Catra was out there, somewhere. That they'd work out their differences *eventually,* whenever Catra wanted to be found. Or whenever Adora stumbled across her. But she also knew that she'd have a great pair of friends until that day came.

~ ~ ~

The three of them sat in their room for hours, laughing and crying and sharing stories from their past. Adora learned that Glimmer's mom, Angella, was the dean of the school. She also learned that Bow was going to school for history, but that he really wanted to study physical therapy.

As the afternoon turned to evening, Glimmer got a text.

"Hey Adora, our friend Hordak's inviting us to a party! Can you believe it? Our first real college party! Wanna come with?" She seemed really excited, and Bow didn't seem surprised. But Adora wasn't sure.

"I don't know, Glimmer," she said, "I don't think it would be right to go there. Catra's supposed to be-"

Glimmer frowned at her. “Adora, take some time for yourself! Catra isn’t here, you know. If she was, it’d be different. But she’s ghosting you, again. Beating yourself up isn’t going to help any.” As much as she hated to admit it, there was some truth in Glimmer’s words.

Adora thought for a moment. “Alright, I’ll come,” she eventually decided.

Bow and Glimmer beamed and high fived each other. They clearly couldn’t wait.

“Let's go, then!” Glimmer yelled, with a whoop whoop. Bow and her left the dorm, waiting outside for Adora.

Adora stayed in her dorm for a minute, still thinking. Glimmer was right. It *was* okay to have fun without her. So why did it feel so wrong? Her head began running through what she could possibly say to Catra when they met again, at least until Glimmer’s voice roused her to put her shoes on and get outside. But she still had Catra in the back of her mind.

Chapter End Notes

Heavy sigh

In the mirror

Chapter Summary

Catra settles into Fright Hall.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C A T R A

Catra let out a brief, frustrated sigh. “I asked you if we were dating yesterday and you said yes. So, which is it? Yes or no? Because if you aren’t even gonna introduce me as your girlfriend, then why are we *together* at all?” As the words left her mouth, Catra winced a little. She was being harsh, but she really was hurt.

Adora opened her mouth again. She just didn’t know when to shut up. “Catra, please, just let me-”

“No,” Catra said sharply. There was no explaining to be done. “I’m going to unpack. Alone. I need time to think about *us.*” she said, tears in the corners of her eyes. “Maybe you should think about us, too.” With that, she whipped around and barreled down the hallway, knocking everyone out of her way as she ran.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck,” her mind repeated as she sprinted down the crowded hall. Through her tear blurred vision and her hair whipping around her, she couldn’t really see where she was going, but eventually she found the staircase down to ground level. She slowed her stride down just enough to see her surroundings a bit clearer. As she realized she didn’t remember the way back to Adora’s car, a sinking feeling consumed her belly and she let out a nervous whine. “Come back, Adora,” she whispered to herself, hugging her sides.

“Why would she follow you? *You* left *her,*” the voice in her head murmured.

Catra sighed and slowly paced around the building, trying to scope out Adora’s car discretely, as though she knew exactly where she were going. The last thing she needed right now was someone offering her help. Catra was so focused on finding the car that she slammed into the hulking, muscular woman who had stopped in front of her with a muted “oomph.”

Catra looked up and the woman looked down. She had white hair, sharply angled eyebrows and black lipstick on.

“Hi!” she said cheerfully, taking a small step back from Catra, still standing directly in front of her.

“...hey,” Catra said distractedly, already having focused her attention back to the infinite parking lot.

“Are you looking for something?” the woman asked, stooping down to get to Catra’s height. “I know the campus pretty well if you need help!” She was so cheerful. It was already getting on Catra’s nerves.

“No, I’m fine,” Catra said coldly, walking away. But the woman just continued following her.

“Well, it’s clear to *me* that you aren’t fine. Look, your hair’s a mess and your eyeliner’s dripping a little. Have you been crying? Are you sure I can’t help? Do you need a hug?” She churned out words so fast Catra could barely understand them before she moved on to the next sentence.

Wiping underneath her eyes with one sleeve self-consciously, Catra conceded, “Fine, you can help. But you better not hug me. I’m looking for a red car. It’s rusty and one of the doors is pale green.” She quickly shot a hostile glare at the woman and gestured to her to follow.

She smiled and began walking beside Catra. “So, what’s your name?” the woman asked. She really was insufferable. The two had just met and Catra had thrown so many signs *not* to talk to her, and that’s exactly what she kept trying to do anyways.

Catra paused and let out a sigh. She probably wouldn’t stop trying until Catra gave the woman her name. She finally conceded, “Catra.”

The woman’s face lit up. “That’s such a pretty name! My name’s Scorpia, but my friends call me-”

“Scorpia’s fine,” Catra said flatly. Her ears perked up as she saw the car she was looking for, parked next to the same nondescript tree. “That’s the car,” she said, pointing it out for Scorpia.

They walked towards it and Catra began pulling her boxes out as Scorpia sat by idly. “You can leave now,” Catra said, hiding her face and adding silently, “just like everyone always does.” But the woman stayed.

“Why would I do that?” she said. Catra looked back at her. She seemed confused. “Do you want help with those boxes?” Scorpia asked.

“...sure,” Catra said carefully, still not entirely trusting Scorpia. She had to want *something,* right?

“Great!” Scorpia said, easily stacking up three boxes and asking where Catra was dorming.

“I uh,” Catra said, fumbling for the room number she had written down on a sticky note right before they had left home. ”Fright hall floor 6, room 6.

Scorpia’s face lit up in awe. “That’s where I’m staying!” she said happily. “That must mean you’re a freshman, right?”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “You’re not a freshman?” she asked, thinking to herself, “why would they put me with an

upperclassman?”

Scorpia nodded and kept blabbing on. “Yeah, I’m a junior, actually. I really like showing freshmen the ropes and helping them out however I can, so I didn’t mind being put with a freshman roommate. I had a really hard time my first year, y’know, so…”

Catra felt white hot fury rising in her chest as her ears tuned out everything Scorpia was saying. She didn’t need to be patronized like this. She should’ve been rooming with Adora. If not Adora, then another freshman. *Definitely* not a junior. She pushed down her anger, though. It wouldn’t do any good to get mad at her roommate a day before the semester even started. She had already burnt the bridge she had just rebuilt with Adora, two times over.

Scrunching her eyes shut, she said, “Fine, let’s go to fright hall then.” She added sarcastically, “Are you sure you know where it is?”

Scorpia’s eyes went wide. “Of course I do!” she said happily. “It’s just this way!” She had completely missed the edge to Catra’s voice.

Letting out another heavy sigh, Catra followed Scorpia to their new home.

The walk to fright hall was long and awkward. It mostly consisted of Scorpia trying to start a conversation, Catra offering brief answers with no room for interpretation, and the shuffling noises of their feet on the pavement. Catra didn’t like Brightmoon. It was too perfect. There was obnoxious blue and purple lettering everywhere, the lawn was maintained so well it felt unnatural, and the tall brick buildings blocked out the sky. She felt out of place amongst the crowds of laughing friends and happy girls in their preppy outfits with perfect makeup. It made her angry just thinking about it. Her mind wandered back to Adora. Of course she’d love it here. Adora was *perfect,* nothing like the sloppy mess of ugliness and self loathing that Catra saw in herself.

“Are you alright? You’ve gotten awfully quiet,” Scorpia said, shifting around the heavy boxes in her arms.

“I’m fine,” Catra snapped. Scorpia didn’t ask if she was actually fine this time.

A few minutes later, they reached the broad brick building, adorned with the red letters, “Fright Hall,” outside. Scorpia announced that they had, in fact, arrived at Fright Hall, and the two stepped inside.

Fright hall was dumpier than Etheria in almost every way. The tiles were faded and peeling in places, the trash bins were full everywhere she looked, and there were far fewer people laughing and chatting in the hallway. Catra loved it. Slowly, a smile spread across her face. This place didn’t feel fake at all. It dripped with reality.

“Well, I’m glad you’re a little happier now that we’re here,” Scorpia chimed in. “Let’s get to the sixth floor!”

They ascended the stairwell, which only smelled slightly of weed, until they reached the sixth floor, stopping at the sixth room. Something was wrong, though. Above the door in big, bold lettering stood the words, “RA OFFICE.”

Catra dropped her box, turning to Scorpia. “Are you fucking kidding me?” she spat. “You’re the RA?”

Scorpia looked down at Catra and smiled cheerfully. “Of course I am! Did I forget to mention that?”

“Why the hell am I rooming with you?” Catra said, her head spinning. This day was not going the way she had planned, at all. She was supposed to be in bed with Adora, doing…

Scorpia’s rambling explanation snapped Catra out of it. “Well, this year was an unnaturally large incoming freshman class,” she explained. “It was so big they actually ran out of rooms. So, they

had to put you and I in the same dorm! You're lucky you still got one," she added.

Catra wanted to tear her face off. Another month of isolation would be better than this. Gritting her teeth, she said, "Great! Why don't we unload just my stuff?" She marched into the room without waiting for Scorpia's response.

And so they did. For the next half hour, the two unloaded Catra's meager belongings into their room, Catra barely keeping her composure and Scorpia intentionally (or unintentionally) missing signals as to how frustrated Catra was with her. Eventually, Catra slumped onto her bed.

"What now?" she thought to herself, exhausted. A few moments later, she heard a knock at the door. Scorpia rushed to answer it, turning back to tell Catra, "Oh don't mind, it's just one of my friends!"

Scorpia opened the door to a short woman with long, purple hair, at least two feet shorter than Scorpia. She let out a shrill screech as the two hugged each other. "Scorpia, it's been *ages!*" the short woman said excitedly. "We really should've gotten together over the summer!"

"I really wish I could've!" Scorpia said, before remembering Catra was in the room. "Entrapta," she said, "meet my new roommate - and best buddy - Catra!" she said, dramatically motioning her arms towards the bed.

Catra waved and gave the new girl, Entrapta, a weak smile. "Nice to meet you," she offered.

"Nice to meet you too!" Entrapta replied, rushing over to shake Catra's hand. The way her hair moved was almost unnatural…

"So are you an upperclassman too, then?" Catra asked.

"Oh yes, I'm actually a senior," she said. "I'll be leaving with a computer science degree *and* an applied mathematics degree in

the spring!" she said, letting out a grating laugh. "What are you studying?" she asked.

"...I haven't decided yet, I'm just doing gen ed credits for now," Catra sighed. Even the loser's dorms was still full of overachievers.

"Nothing wrong with that!" Entrapta said with a smile. They were both so optimistic. It seemed so unnatural.

The three talked about nothing in particular. Entrapta had a boyfriend, another senior, with a 4.0 record. "He's in engineering," she added. The two had founded the school's robotics team. Interestingly, Scorpia seemed impartial to him, always dismissively waving him off when he came up in conversation. Scorpia was studying chemistry, something about her moms contributing some important tidbit of knowledge that Catra couldn't have cared less about.

Despite their cheeriness, Catra found herself growing to like the dynamic the three of them had. "Maybe I can get used to them," Catra thought to herself in a particularly hopeful moment.

After a short while, Entrapta's phone buzzed, and she squealed, rolling around on Scorpia's bed. "My boyfriend invited us to a party!" she told Scorpia excitedly.

"Sounds like fun!" Scorpia said. "Can Catra come?" she said, wiggling her eyebrows invitingly.

"Sure, I don't see why not!" Entrapta said.

Catra really didn't want to go to a party with people she had just met, full of even more people she had *never* met. Then she remembered that she really didn't want to put herself around alcohol, and that sealed the deal.

"Actually, I don't know if I want to," Catra said, looking down dejectedly. There was no way she was telling these people - she almost called them friends - that she had alcohol problems. No way.

“Why not?” Scorpia prodded. “You can meet some new people, forget about whatever’s on your mind, y’know, just have fun!”

“Have you ever smoked before?” Entrapta asked curiously. “My boyfriend’s bringing along a ton of weed. Pretty much the entire campus buys it from him. It’ll be a ton of fun!” she said.

Gears turned in Catra’s head. Weed wasn’t alcohol. And she *could* distract herself from her problems with Adora.

“Fine,” Catra said, standing up. “Count me in.”

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry I haven't uploaded a new chapter in a few days, I've been moving to a different state the last couple days so things have been a little hectic. This chapter might be a little less refined than the ones prior, so sorry about that. I should have some more time for writing a couple days from now. Thanks for the continued kind words!

No Strings

Chapter Summary

Catra goes to a party

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stood in front of the bathroom mirror, staring not at her slightly disheveled reflection, but the mirror itself. It was warped and well worn, with little red nail polish flecks on one side and a cracked bottom corner. Focusing back on herself, she sighed. Catra hated her face. She hated it so much it hurt. And that mirror was bothering her. Even though this was her first time in the dorm bathroom, the little crack in the mirror seemed almost familiar.

She pulled a few products out of her makeup bag and began getting herself cleaned up for the party. As she did, her mind began to wander. After tonight, she'd have to start going to classes. For a few months. Yippee. Then finals. After that, winter break.

"Adora and I will make up by then," she decided. "We'll get back together, whatever that looks like now, and everything will be fine." Her self-assurance rang hollow in her gut.

She thought back to Aunt Weaver, to where she'd have to return to if they *didn't* make up.

Suddenly the world went black, and she found herself back in her childhood home.

Catra examined her surroundings in a panic. She was standing in the kitchen. The walls were coated in grime and the floor was cracked and filthy. The kitchen table, scarred from when Catra used to cut into it instead of herself, sat against the far wall. She could feel herself suffocating in the stagnant air.

At the edge of her vision stood the subject of so many of her childhood nightmares. It was a dark wood chair. Presumably it had come in a set with the kitchen table. Around its arms and legs ran deep gouges where the varnish had long since been stripped away by long, narrow stretches of plastic. Catra let out a shivering breath and she felt her heart stop. She heard a noise behind her and turned around quickly.

Aunt Weaver towered over her. Her eyes were bloodshot and her body swayed slightly. Catra stood looking up at her Aunt for a moment before she spoke. “What the hell are you looking at?” Weaver said crankily, narrowing her eyes.

Catra opened her mouth to respond, but no words came out. Only a slight squeaking sound.

Her Aunt stooped down to her level on unsteady feet. Catra could feel her hot breath against her face. “We’ve been over this,” she said flatly. Then, she shouted, “USE YOUR WORDS!”

Catra’s joints locked up.

“Nobody’s going to know what you want if you don’t talk to them,” her aunt continued. “What do you want from me?” she breathed in a terrifying tone.

Catra couldn’t have spoken if she wanted to.

“Okay. I see how it is,” her aunt said, almost too quiet to hear. She grabbed the chair and dragged it across the kitchen floor, its legs letting out a shrill, tortured screech.

“No!” Catra screamed, turning around and trying to run away. But it was no use. She felt her aunt’s nails digging into her wrist, a wicked gleam in her eyes.

Weaver pinned her to the chair with her body and pulled the bundle of zip ties from her pocket. The cracked mirror on the wall reflected Catra’s own terrified expression back to her.

“No! Please! Adora! Anyone!” Catra wailed and pleaded as the ties grew closer and her aunt's nails dug further into her wrist…

Then, she snapped out of it. She was on the floor in the dorm bathroom. She had probably blacked out. Slowly easing the pressure of her claws, she examined her wrist. There were indents where she had pressed them into her skin, but no blood.

She let out a hiss of frustration. Catra didn’t have time for this. She had half an hour to be across campus, and here she was mewling on the bathroom floor. She stood up too quickly, nearly stumbling back to the ground but catching the smudged sink on her way back down. Now she was covered in floor grime. Quickly washing her hands and slapping on new eyeliner and mascara, she ducked into her dorm to change.

“We *will* make up,” she muttered to herself as she opened the door. They had to.

Scorpia and Entrapta clearly hadn’t waited for her. The door was locked when she opened it, and the room was empty. They were probably halfway across campus already. Cursing herself for taking so long, she tore through her wardrobe trying to find something to wear. She eventually settled on a cami crop top, a black sheer jacket, and a pair of shredded black jeans. Pausing for a moment on her way out, she threw on various necklaces and bracelets until she found a few that vaguely matched. Then she ran out the door.

~ ~ ~

Catra stood outside the frat house, streams of people walking in and out in disorganized clusters. The cool night air kissed her skin, loud music pounded her eardrums, and the windows of the house barraged her eyes with strobing colors. Strangely, she noticed a white and green sports car with blacked out windows pulling away

from the party. It looked expensive and out of place here, and Catra couldn't help but wonder whose it was.

She checked her phone. 9:23. Even though she hadn’t been to a ton of parties in high school, she figured 20 minutes would still pass as fashionably late. Taking a deep breath, she pushed her way into the crowd towards the house.

Unsurprisingly, the inside of the party was even more chaotic. Huge speakers pumped up to max volume meant she could feel the music vibrating her bones. Every room was full of people drinking and dancing and getting sloppy with each other. As anxious as Catra was, a little part of her felt liberated. Nobody knew who she was here. She could be anyone she wanted to be.

She continued pushing her way around the party, trying to make her way to Scorpia and Entrapta. Eventually, she found them smoking on the second floor, along with a couple other people standing in a line.

“Scorpia! Hey,” Catra said, a little happy to recognize *someone,* even if it was her overly cheerful roommate.

“Hey Wildcat!” she said, letting out a low chuckle. “Do you like that nickname? I can call you wildcat and you can call me-”

Entrapta cut her off. “Hi Catra!” she said, having just finished her joint. She gestured over to the man sitting next to her. He was tall and pale, with dark blue hair. “This is my boyfriend, Hordak!” she exclaimed. Hordak did not seem enthused.

“Who are you?” he mumbled in a deep voice between puffs.

She spoke up. This didn’t look promising already. “I’m Catra. Scorpia’s new roommate,” she said.

Hordak laughed heartily. “The freshman!” He stuck his hand out mockingly. “Nice to meet you, what’s your major?” he sneered.

Catra's heart sank. She cursed her past self. Why did she think going to an upperclassmen party was a good idea?

She spoke up again. "Listen, it was nice meeting you, but I should go."

Scorpia stood up. "Nono, you can't leave yet! You're gonna have fun! I promise!" she begged, seemingly believing her own words. She turned to Hordak. "Catra's never smoked before, can she try a joint?" she asked. Catra had never wanted to reach out and slap someone across the face so badly.

Hordak turned to Catra. "I don't know you," he said flatly. "Are you gonna pay up?" he asked, gesturing to the line of people before him.

Entrapta turned to him to say something, but Catra didn't stick around to figure out what. She had already disappeared back into the crowd. She staggered around until she found a table with an empty spot and anchored herself to it, choking back tears. It just wasn't fair. She couldn't control anything in her life. "I'll never be happy," she thought to herself, lifting her forehead off the table and pounding it back down hard. Not that it did anything to quell the complete sense of numbness swallowing her body.

"Hey! Watch what you're doin'!" the guy next to her yelled above the music. She turned to him, noticing the red solo cup she had almost knocked off the table. A million thoughts raced through her head in an instant. She had *promised* Adora that she would try to get clean. She also didn't care what Adora thought about her anymore. She didn't care about anything anymore. A tiny voice reminded her, "what about the promise you made to yourself?" But she didn't listen. In a single swift motion, she downed the entire solo cup. The liquid trickled down her throat like a cold flame, making her feel alive again. It made her feel good.

"What the hell!" the guy complained loudly. He looked around and yelled, "hey, this girl just downed my drink!" But nobody was listening.

Catra threw the cup behind her into the crowd. She pulled the guy down to her level by the collar of his shirt. “Listen asshole,” she spat, pulling him in even closer, “are you gonna complain and get shredded, or are you gonna show me where to get more?”

He chose the latter option.

For a time Catra meandered around the party, swirling her cup around and staring at her reflection in it. She thought about how much she hated herself, how meaningless life was, the anguish that she knew awaited her in the future by simply choosing to remain alive. But as the night crawled on, the alcohol started to work it’s magic. Her body loosened up, and her mind stopped thinking. She was floating on clouds, and she didn’t want to come down. So she drank more, and more, and more.

Catra started to have fun. Her head swam with mirrors and chairs and booze bottles and colorful strips of plastic. She laughed her head off at stupid jokes and danced and hugged people she didn’t know. The nagging voice in the back of her head said this was wrong, something about Adora and about getting better. But she didn’t care.

Later on that night she found herself dancing with a particularly pretty brunette for a long time. Even as drunk as she was, Catra managed to land a few witty remarks, and her dancing was passable too. Then, during one particularly long song, the two gradually grew closer, and closer, and closer. They were within breathing distance when suddenly Catra closed her eyes, leaned in, and kissed her.

Her brain set off alarm bells as soon as her lips landed. This didn’t feel right. This wasn’t like her kisses with Adora. This was a mistake. But she kept kissing anyway. Her tongue found the smooth spot she loved on the roof of Adora’s mouth, only to find it wasn’t there. This was a different mouth on a different person. Catra opened her eyes and picked a blonde in a crimson dress out of the crowd. *Her* shade of crimson. “Adora?” she thought to herself. Catra tried to pull away, but the girl kept pulling her back

in whenever she tried to escape. When she finally pulled away for a desperate breath, Catra broke free and shoved her away. She tried to find the blonde again, but she was gone. In her wake was a path of displaced people leading right to Catra, pushed aside by a broad set of hockey player shoulders. Adora stood before her in a lovely crimson dress, her makeup done to a tee. She looked angry.

“Catra,” Adora said, a dangerous edge to her voice.

“Hey Adora,” Catra said in a dry voice followed by a light chuckle.

“What. Are. You. Doing?” Adora asked, her eyes seemingly bulging out of her head.

“Well, I’m at this college party talking to my best friend-”

She raised a finger, her face growing increasingly angry by the second. “Best friend?” she asked, hurt shining in her fiery eyes.

“Fuck,” Catra thought. “Listen, I’ve been drinking-”

“Why? Catra, why?” she said, lowering her head down into her hands. “Do you remember what you told me before we left?” she asked solemnly.

“What I told you?” Catra retorted. “How about what *you* told *me*. That we were definitely dating? Ring a bell?”

“If you're so dead-set on us being together, why are you kissing some random ass girl? That's no excuse!” Adora screamed.

Rage burned in Catra’s belly. She didn’t understand. “You said we weren't dating first! And you have no idea the shit I go through daily,” she snapped back.

“What YOU go through daily?” Adora yelled. “I’ve seen it, Catra,” she said bitterly. “For twelve years I’ve seen it. And I don’t know how to help you anymore if you’re just going to sabotage yourself over and over again!”

“You weren’t there for me!” Catra screeched.

“I shouldn’t have to be!” Adora screamed back.

“Oh right, because I’M always the issue. My Aunt Weaver was right. I should just go die in a hole and bury my own body. I’m an awful person who doesn’t deserve ANYTHING. Sorry, I almost forgot.” Catra spat. The party was starting to quiet down around them, but she didn’t care.

“You ARE an awful person!” Adora yelled hoarsely.

The rest of the room went silent.

Catra stared at Adora. So many things boiled in her belly. Betrayal. Wounded pride. Frustration. Hatred. Pain. White hot fury.

“And you aren’t?” Catra said quietly, staring right into Adora’s eyes.

“EXCUSE ME?” Adora roared.

“You heard me,” Catra sneered, laughing cynically. “You’re miss high and mighty. Ooh, look at me, I got adopted into a gated community by a rich man who buys me everything I’ve ever wanted. I get perfect grades and I’m a star hockey player and everyone ADORES ME. Your life is perfect. You wouldn’t know a challenge if it bit you in the ass,” she sneered.

“I do know challenges, because I know you!” Adora shouted back.

“You know what?” Catra screamed, “I’m glad your dad died!”

Adora’s face shifted from white hot anger to heart wrenching agony in an instant. It was as if she’d been shot in the chest. Hot tears rushed down her face. The room was so silent you could hear each drop hit the floor.

Catra realized in that instant that she’d taken things too far. She'd given herself a death sentence.

Adora looked down at her, eyes darkened with pain and wet with tears. “Goodbye Catra,” she gasped, before walking out of the party.

“Adora…” Catra said. “Please! Don’t leave!” she shouted, on the verge of tears herself.

When it became clear that she wasn’t coming back, she started screaming again. “Fine! Leave me like you always do! Go crawl to your rich asshole friends with your millions of dollars! I’ll be a hundred times better without you! You’ll see!”

There was no reply. Adora really wasn’t coming back.

Catra collapsed, sobbing.

The party sat staring at the broken girl in the middle of the room, until someone turned the music back on and they all got back to dancing.

All of them but one.

She would’ve taken the zipties over this any day.

Chapter End Notes

Back to Adora next chapter c;<

Xerox Dreams pt. 1

Chapter Summary

Catra meets a new friend and buys an orange

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey, Catra!" a young Adora shouted to her, waving her hand in the air. They were in the lunchroom of their elementary school. Catra bounded over to Adora and sat down next to her on the long, plastic lunch table bench.

"What do you have today?" Catra squeaked, eyeing Adora's lunchbox hungrily. Her dad had taken up the habit of packing an extra lunch with Adora every day so Catra could have something to eat, too. Catra always felt warm when she was around him, even if she had only seen him a few times.

A toothy grin spread across Adora's face as she dumped out the contents of her lunch box. "Sandwiches, cookies, and an orange!" she squealed happily.

"I've never had an orange," Catra whispered curiously. She had always seen pictures of them when they were learning the alphabet, but that's all they ever were. Pictures.

"They're my favorite color *and* fruit!" Adora declared happily. She shoved one into Catra's palm. "Here, try it!" she said.

Catra held the orange up to her mouth and prepared to bite into it, before Adora started laughing.

"What!" Catra hissed at her, dropping the fruit on the table.

"You have to peel it first!" she said as though it were obvious, showing Catra how to fit her finger underneath the skin and pull it

away, before popping a slice into her mouth. Her eyes closed and her mouth let out a loud noise of approval.

Catra was in awe. Clawing through the thick skin was so satisfying. “It’s my favorite too!” Catra declared after eating the first bite. It tasted like grass.

Catra slowly peeled open her eyes. Her mind was foggy, and her head ached with the dull throb of hangover. She felt like she’d been run over by a truck. She could feel dewy grass around her. Her body was damp. Lifting her head, she surveyed her surroundings. She had been lying face down on the grass outside of the frat house, presumably for the entire night. The lawn was littered with solo cups and other scraps of trash from the party. Above her, the overcast sky glowed softly as the sun rose above the tree line.

“What happened last night?” she asked herself groggily. She was so exhausted she could barely put that thought together.

“Maybe I’ll just lie down for a little longer,” Catra muttered into the ground. She took one last glance around her before she fell back asleep. People were walking on the sidewalk a few feet to her side, all headed in the same direction.

“This early in the morning?” she thought, her brain nearly blowing a fuse trying to work out what was going on. Then, it came to her. Catra sat up so quickly she almost doubled over and threw up. “Fuck,” was the only word that came to mind. Today was the first day of classes, and by the looks of it they started in a few minutes. She examined herself.

Her jacket was tattered and stained, as though she’d been trampled over. “Fuck,” she thought again. This was one of her favorites.
Her crop and jeans were filthy, but at least they didn’t look damaged.

She whipped out her phone camera. Her face was a mess. Tear marks streaked down her cheeks, and what was left of her mascara had bled down her eyes. “Wow, I look like death,” she thought to herself miserably. What had happened last night?

She looked at the time. 8:55. She had to be across campus for first lecture in 5 minutes. “Fuck.”

Catra staggered to her feet and brushed herself off the best she could. The night started coming back to her. Walking into the party, meeting Hordak, drinking, the brunette, Adora…

“Fuck!” Catra screamed at herself, pressing her fingers so hard into the bridge of her nose that her nails left little crescent indents. She started hyperventilating and she could feel tears welling up in the corners of her eyes. She couldn’t break down again. Not on the first day of classes. She *had* to start walking to lecture. She’d still be late and look like a mess, but at least she’d be there.

She started the long walk to humanities hall on wobbly legs, fighting back sobs as she remembered everything she had said to Adora. Everything Adora had said to her. “Fuck, fuck, fuck…”

She heard the sound of tires on the road behind her. Glancing back, she saw a white and green sports car headed her way. It looked familiar, somehow. Then she remembered she had seen it leaving the party just as she had arrived.

She stopped and tried to flag it down, waving her arms frantically. Maybe she could catch a ride to class.

To her surprise, the car actually pulled over to the side of the road. The blacked out window opened just enough for her to hear a voice from within. “Need a ride?” a deep, regal voice asked her. She was taken aback by how old it sounded; this definitely wasn’t a student’s car.

“Sure,” Catra choked out. She heard the door click as the lock released and the door opened on its own. Catra climbed inside.

The interior of the car was probably the most expensive thing Catra had ever seen. Its white leather seats were unnervingly spotless, and the dashboard was shined to perfection. Pale green light glowed from led lights along the floor. She looked to the driver's seat. In it sat a tall, pale, older man with long silver hair pulled back into braids and a perfectly maintained beard. Much like the seats of his car, his suit was blindingly white.

He gave Catra a once over and smiled knowingly. "Rough night?" he asked sarcastically, turning back to the windshield and starting the car again.

Catra didn't reply. There was nothing she could possibly say to explain the state she was in, and she definitely didn't care to try with someone she had just met. "Can you drive me to humanities?" she asked, her hoarse voice breaking a little as she spoke.

"Gladly," the man mused. The car pulled away silently and they started the short drive to humanities hall.

Catra watched the man as he drove. Something was deeply unsettling about him, but she couldn't quite put her finger on it. The way he suddenly jerked the steering wheel, or maybe the indescribable look in his piercing green eyes. Regardless, he was helping her out, so Catra put her unease to rest.

"Who are you, again?" Catra asked, breaking the long silence.

The man chuckled to himself. "New student I assume?" he asked, cutting Catra off before she had the chance to answer. "Vice President Hordak Senior," he said. "You may call me Prime."

~ ~ ~

A few minutes later, the car pulled up to the outside of Humanities. Catra turned to Prime to thank him, but he waved her off. "Go to class," he said, pressing a button on the dashboard to open her door.

“Thanks,” Catra managed while climbing out of the car.

Prime smiled. “We’ll see each other again, Catra,” he said. Then the door closed, and the car pulled away silently.

Catra started walking into the hall. There weren’t any other students walking in around her: she was definitely late. She stopped for a moment to strip off her ruined jacket and throw it away. Then, she realized something that chilled her to the core.

She had never told Prime her name.

Catra shook her head. She probably had and just forgotten. But, as she walked into the lecture hall, she couldn’t help but feel that her gut feeling was probably right. Something *was* off about that man.

Catra quietly took a seat at the back of the lecture hall. The lecture itself was probably mind numbingly boring, but Catra wasn’t paying attention to a word of it. Instead, her mind was reminding her of everything Adora had told her last night over and over again.

“I don’t know how to help you anymore if you’re just going to sabotage yourself!”
“I shouldn’t have to be there for you!”
“I do know challenges because I know you!”
“You are an awful person!”

“We were supposed to be friends,” Catra whispered to herself, choking back tears.

She picked up her phone and desperately texted Adora.

“I’m so sorry, Adora. I am an awful person, and I’ve been an awful friend. I want to meet up and talk about what I said. I was drunk and I didn’t mean it.”

It was definitely inadequate, but what else could she say? Catra sent it and prayed for a response, holding her breath for what felt

like an hour.

It never came.

The lecture concluded, and Catra texted her again.

"Adora, please say something. I don't know what else I can say. I fucked up bad, and I'm so sorry."

She sat in that seat at the back of the lecture hall staring at her phone long after everyone had begun walking to the next period. The reply never came.

Catra's mind went into panic mode, and she started digging her claws into her arms before she realized and stopped herself.

Forcing herself to take deep breaths, she started walking to her next class. People gawked at her disheveled appearance as she paced down the sidewalk. She didn't even have the energy to shoot them dirty looks.

Stumbling into her next lecture, she texted Adora again.

"Please respond. I'm so sorry."

The lecture crawled on, and Catra couldn't do anything but stare at her phone, waiting for something, anything from Adora.

There was no reply.

After an eternity, the lecture concluded. Catra walked solemnly to the closest dining hall. The world might have been grey, but she could feel her stomach growling. Her belly was almost as empty as her mind. She knew she had to eat, but she didn't know what she could possibly stomach. Eventually she settled on a small orange and sat down alone, rested her head on her arms, and stared at it. The orange stared back.

A few minutes later, someone shouted her name excitedly behind her. Catra didn't bother turning around: it wasn't Adora's voice, so

what did it matter?

Scorpia sat down beside her. Her joyful expression dropped, and she gave Catra a concerned look when she saw the state she was in. “Hey, you okay?” she asked tentatively. “You never came back from the party last night.”

Catra didn’t even acknowledge her.

Scorpia let out a nervous laugh. “I, uh, I’m really sorry about Hordak. He’s usually cooler than that.”

Yet again, Catra didn’t respond. The orange was her world now.

Scorpia leaned closer to her. “Was that you shouting last night? The whole party quieted down, I could even hear it upstairs,” she whispered.

She waited a minute, then continued talking in a hushed tone. “If it was, I’m sorry for whatever happened. And if you ever want to talk, I’m here, y’know?”

Scorpia waited until it was clear Catra wasn’t going to respond, then sighed heavily and walked away with a pained, “see ya later, then.”

Catra stared at that orange for an unknowable amount of time. Then, it happened. She felt her phone buzz in her pocket. Her heart dropped and she could feel her face go pale. Frantically, she pulled it out and desperately read the brief message that Adora had sent. She almost dropped her phone.

She dialed Adora’s number. There was no response.

She dialed Adora again. This time, it didn’t even ring before it went to voicemail.

She dialed Adora again. A message played informing her she’d been blocked by that number.

Catra’s mind cracked in half. Her eyes wandered back to the orange, her last tether to reality. She had no tears left to cry.

She didn’t go to her third lecture.

Chapter End Notes

I, personally, think it's a crime that Catra never got to say "fuck"
Back from moving in yippee
Also I was eating sushi while writing this and my cat was going ballistic trying to get to it.

Xerox Dreams pt. 2

Chapter Summary

Adora makes a decision

A D O R A

Adora stumbled into her dorm, barely managing to unlock the door through her tear-blurred vision. She stood, hyperventilating, in the middle of the dark room, her mind swimming with everything that had just gone wrong.

The hypocrisy of Catra being upset at her for not saying they were dating, then neglecting to say it herself.

Cheating on her with a random girl their first day on campus.

Catra's lapse on her promise to quit drinking the day after she had made it.

Calling Adora an awful person for the circumstances she had been born into.

Then, the straw that broke the camel's back.

Adora collapsed onto her bed, her mind pounding against her skull with Catra's words.

"I'm glad your dad died."

She shivered a little and fought back the urge to start crying again. The third word upset Adora even more than the full phrase. "Your." Adora's father had made it clear that he saw Catra as a second daughter. He had done everything for her for the better part of 12 years, never asking *anything* of her. The fact that Catra's subconscious didn't see him as her father after all that was flat out disturbing, even drunk and in the heat of a fiery

argument. If that's how Catra saw her dad, how did Catra see *her*?

Adora rolled over and buried her face in her pillow. She wondered if Catra would even remember their fight tomorrow. Maybe she'd have to explain the whole thing over again. Tears slowly rolled down her face, absorbing into the pillow below her. She heard a gentle knock on the door behind her.

"Come in," Adora groaned.

The door slowly opened, and Adora heard two sets of footsteps shuffle into the room silently, closing the door behind them. One sat down on Glimmer's bed, one stood next to hers. The dorm stayed silent for a moment, then Glimmer spoke up.

"Are you okay?" she asked softly. When Adora didn't respond, she kept talking.

"I know it hurts. So bad. But it can really help talking about this stuff. If you want to."

Adora let out a long sigh and pulled herself into a sitting position. Bow sat on Glimmer's bed, and Glimmer stood at her side. Both looked deeply concerned for her. Taking a deep breath, Adora explained everything.
The first day she had met Catra, the abuse she faced at home, their years together in grade school, their first kiss, their dad, their admission of feelings for each other. She laid it all on the table.

Halfway through her story, Adora started crying again. "It's all my fault, I fucked up so bad, if only I had brought her with me…" she sobbed.

Adora fully expected them to be unsympathetic, to dig into her for not doing enough. But instead, Glimmer pulled her into a tight hug. Adora's tears rolled down her face and absorbed into Glimmer's shirt.

“Adora, I’m so sorry,” she whispered, sounding like she was on the edge of tears herself. “This is not your fault. None of it is.”

Bow stepped forward and wrapped his arms around both of them. “I know we only met you like, a couple hours ago,” he began, “but I really don’t think you’ve done anything wrong. You’ve always been there for her, even when most people probably wouldn’t have. The only time you weren’t was when your dad was literally dying, Adora. You’re an amazing friend.”

“But how do I stay with her now? After so long… after she said…” she sobbed. Her mind was breaking in two. She still loved Catra, but this fight was too much for her to handle.

“You can take a break,” Glimmer said. “Even if it’s just a few days. She’ll still be there when you come back,” she promised.

Could she really just abandon Catra like that? It didn’t feel right, not when she was going through so much pain, too. What if she relapsed?

“But she needs me,” Adora whispered, half to herself. “If I’m not there for her, she might get worse again.”

Bow pulled out of the hug and said, “You can’t help her if she’s dragging you down with her. I think if you take some time to recover and cool down, then go back to her, you’ll both resolve everything.”

“Maybe…” Adora said quietly. It didn’t feel right, but maybe Bow was right. She couldn’t help Catra if she spiraled down after her.

“You can always think about it too,” Bow said gently. “Nobody’s forcing you to make a decision right now.”

Adora sighed. “Yeah.” She yawned and realized how late it was, then remembered the first day of classes and hockey practice were both tomorrow. “I’m gonna go to bed, I think.” she said tiredly, lying down and rolling over to face the wall. She really was exhausted.

She heard Glimmer say, “Please just remember we’re here for you, okay?” before shutting off the lights and saying “Goodnight, Adora.” Bow slipped out the door, and before long she could hear Glimmer’s gentle breaths indicating that she had fallen asleep. It was good white noise, but it couldn’t quite compare to Catra’s gentle purring.

Even though Glimmer and Bow had diffused her a little, Adora’s head still swam with the ramifications of her argument with Catra. They had disagreed in the past, sure, but never had it gotten that out of control. Eventually she managed to fall asleep, and all too soon she was pulled back to reality by the alarm on her phone.

She sat up and checked it for any messages from Catra. There weren’t any.

Getting out of bed, she realized just how tense her body was. Had she slept that way the entire night? Adora stretched and heard her back pop in a couple places. Then, she got along with her morning routine, periodically checking her phone for messages from Catra.

By the time the sun was peeking above the horizon, Adora and Glimmer had walked to the dining hall to get breakfast. She kept her eyes peeled for Catra, but didn’t see her anywhere.

Adora grabbed an orange and a coffee and got in line to pay. “Are you looking for her?” Glimmer asked gently, falling into line behind her.

She wordlessly nodded, craning her neck to try and pick Catra out from the crowd of students around her. But she wasn’t there.

They sat down and ate. Glimmer seemed to thoroughly enjoy her muffin, giving Bow a kiss on the cheek when he passed by to say hi. Adora glumly poked at her orange and sipped her coffee before the two broke off and went to her first lecture.

Math was never Adora’s favorite subject, but it was her father’s. She thought about the long nights they had spent together when

Adora was in elementary school going over times tables. The smiles he gave her when she got a problem right. She found herself tearing up as she felt her phone buzz in her pocket. She pulled it out and checked it quickly, her heart leaping into her throat when she saw it was from Catra. She quickly opened the message and read it.

"I'm so sorry, Adora. I am an awful person, and I've been an awful friend. I want to meet up and talk about what I said. I was drunk and I didn't mean it."

Even though she'd been urgently awaiting Catra's message, something inside Adora broke now that it was actually here. She tried to type a response, but her hands were petrified. No matter how much she willed them, they just refused to type. She stared at the screen, glowing bright in the dim light of the lecture hall, before turning it off and placing the phone back in her pocket. She couldn't respond. Not now.

Trying her best to pay attention to the lecture, Adora's mind kept wandering back to the unanswered message awaiting her. It had said about what Adora expected, but could she really just talk about it and move on that quickly? She wasn't so sure.

At the end of the lecture, her phone buzzed again. Feeling a nugget of dread in her belly as she pulled out her phone, Adora opened the message.

"Adora, please say something. I don't know what else I can say. I fucked up bad, and I'm so sorry."

As she stared at the words, Adora felt her mind go dull. This whole situation was so sad, and the more she thought about it the more Adora believed she hadn't actually done anything wrong. Catra was to blame here, and she couldn't just forgive and forget for something this big. Maybe she did need a break.

She guiltily slid the phone back into her pocket and started walking to hockey practice. Before she arrived, another text from

Catra came through.

“Please respond. I’m so sorry.”

Adora felt the pit in her stomach return again, and slid the phone back into her pocket. She didn’t want to come across as callous, but what could she possibly say? That everything was fine? She couldn’t lie to herself like that, and she couldn’t lie to Catra either. So, she put her phone away and continued her walk to the ice rink.

Brightmoon’s skate facility was one of the best in the country by far. It had massive vaulted ceilings and bleachers that could seat a thousand people. But as she walked in for the first time, Adora felt empty. She looked around bleakly as she walked towards the locker rooms, staying silent as her teammates tried to introduce themselves.

She channeled her frustration into the warm ups, then into the practice game they played. Muscle memory kicked in, and Adora felt like she was one with the ice, even if it had been months since she last played. Her peers bickered and exchanged friendly banter around her, but her personality reflected the ice perfectly.

She did well in the practice game, scoring every shot she took and obviously impressing Coach Razz, the little old lady who looked far too frail to be a hockey instructor. Soon, practice was over and she faced her old dilemma again.
Adora sat on the locker room bench, her hands trembling as she typed the response she had decided on letter by letter.

“I really just think I need some time.”

She took a deep breath, and hit the send button.

Seconds after the text was delivered, Catra called her. Adora let it ring. She didn’t have it in her to talk with Catra right now, something she hoped her text would convey.

Then, Catra called again. Adora sighed with frustration. What part of her text didn't Catra understand? She pressed the large, "Block Number" button below, instantly feeling guilty but knowing it was the only way Catra would stop.

"We'll talk, I just need some time," she whispered to herself.

Glimpse of the Void

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to a team dinner

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had been one week since their fight, and Adora was doing great.

She had so much more time to do things now. She was getting to know Bow and Glimmer better by the day. She had quickly risen above the other freshmen on the hockey team. Coach Razz had guaranteed her a spot in the first game of the season, a massive deal for a freshman.

Deep down, Adora knew the truth, though. A truth she couldn't hide from forever. Her extra time to herself always ended up with her sitting in bed wondering just why she felt so alone. Hanging out with Bow and Glimmer *was* fun, but she couldn't help but feel like a third wheel, constantly reminding her of the hole in her heart. And even though hockey was going well, the only thing Adora's brain could think about when she was out on the ice was the missing girl who was supposed to be cheering her on from the bleachers. It didn't help that they were so patronizing when she met their repeated attempts to engage her in friendly banter with blank stares.

It had been one week since their fight, and Adora was doing terrible.

And yet, something still stopped her from unblocking Catra.

Adora felt her head slump down onto the table, her chin dipping into something wet. She snapped back to reality, realizing that she was in the dining hall. There was a bowl of cereal below her head,

and Bow and Glimmer were giving her very concerned looks from across the table.

“Adora?” Glimmer asked nervously. “Are you alright?”

She quickly tore a napkin out of the dispenser and mopped the milk off her chin. “I’m great, just tired,” Adora lied. She wasn’t tired. She’d had more than enough time to catch up on sleep the past week.

“...Right,” Bow said. He clearly wasn’t buying it. “Are you gonna be okay for your game tomorrow? Do you think you’re sick?”

“You have been sleeping a lot lately,” Glimmer muttered, half to herself.

“I said I’m fine,” Adora insisted. “I’m not worried at all about the game.” That much was true. Plus, the hockey team had organized a ton of meetups outside of practice times to decompress.

“You remember the dinner tonight, right?” Glimmer asked her. “My mom’s been bringing it up nonstop since I mentioned one of my friends was on the team.”

President Angella was holding a dinner for the hockey team that night, something Adora had been keenly aware of for the last week.

“I remember it,” Adora sighed. Even though it was meant to get the team hyped up for the first game of the season, she was anything but. Her mind kept wandering back to Catra…

“Adora!” Glimmer said, raising her voice slightly and pounding her hands on the table. She had almost let her chin dip into the cereal again.

“Sorry!” Adora said, feeling a little guilty for being so removed from their conversation.

Glimmer sighed. “I said, do you think it might ease your nerves a little if I go with you? She might be a little less scary if I’m there too, and I want to catch up with her. She’s leaving for a national conference of colleges tomorrow, so it’ll probably be the last time I get to see her until she gets back.”

Adora blinked. Was it really fine if Glimmer just invited herself to a team function?

As if reading her mind, Glimmer said, “Oh don’t worry, the team won’t mind. I have to go to a lot of campus functions, anyway. Nobody will bat an eye.”

“Sure, sounds good then,” Adora said, trying to sound glad. It *was* nice that she’d have extra company at the dinner, but Adora knew very well that Glimmer could never hope to replace what she had with Catra.

“Does that mean *our* dinner’s off?” Bow asked, his tone reflecting that of a sad puppy.

“Sorry hun, I’ll make it up to you,” Glimmer said, kissing him on the cheek. Bow let out a resigned sigh, and the three parted ways to start walking to their classes.

~ ~ ~

Adora sat behind her closet door, staring at the row of clothes, waiting for something to catch her eye. She didn’t know what to wear. Everything was so thoroughly saturated with memories of Catra.

“Hey Glimmer?” Adora asked from behind her closet door. “How formal do you think I should be? How formal do you usually dress for these?” She was starting to get really stressed out.

“You’re overthinking it!” Glimmer shouted through the door. “Not casual, not fancy.”

Adora sighed. She eventually settled on a light button-up and a pair of dress joggers, throwing on a jacket over-top. She walked outside to Glimmer, dressed in a lavender strapless dress.

"You look great!" Glimmer said, before frowning and tilting her head to the side. "Aren't you missing accessories?" she asked.

Adora sighed again. She had always borrowed Catra's accessories. She had great taste in them, something Adora knew she didn't possess. "I actually left them all at my house," Adora said, prompting a disappointed look from Glimmer.

"Here, do you want to borrow some of my stuff?" she offered, before Adora shook her head. Glimmer pouted for a minute, thinking. "Okay, well what about this?" she asked, pulling a big hair pin out of her vanity drawer. Adora figured she probably wouldn't stop asking until she took *something*, so she just accepted it and put her hair up.

"You look great!" Glimmer said excitedly, as the two walked out the door. The President's House was only a few minutes walk from their dorm.

"Thanks, you too," Adora said weakly. Not because she didn't like Glimmer's dress, but because her mind was consumed by thoughts of her missing half. If she was here, Catra would probably tease her for her lack of style. "Hey Adora," she'd say with that bratty edge to her voice. "A button down and joggers *again*? Really?" she'd tease, then Adora would make a smart comeback, and the two would hold hands like nothing had happened. Maybe they'd even kiss. Adora's heart flourished in her chest and she could almost feel her rough hands catching on the curves of Catra's slender body…

"I asked, are you ready to go?" Glimmer said impatiently. Adora had zoned out again.

"Oh- of course!" she said, a little flustered. She hoped her cheeks weren't as flushed as they felt.

~ ~ ~

After a walk where Adora repeatedly assured Glimmer that she was fine, the two reached their destination. It was a massive brick house set at the very back of campus, in a much more wooded area. There was a massive fountain of a unicorn, the school's mascot, that the pathway looped around. As the two approached the door, they were greeted by some of Adora's teammates. Some of the freshmen were surprised at Glimmer's presence, but many upperclassmen weren't.

"Shall we go in?" Glimmer said. She didn't wait for Adora's response, stepping right inside.

As Glimmer led her through the house, she seemed to relax more than Adora had ever seen. Slowly, Adora understood why. Glimmer would make brief comments like, "I stained that side table with nail polish when I was little," or, "There used to be a doll house in that corner." Glimmer's mom was president, so she must've lived on campus for most of her life. In this house. It made sense why she had wanted to tag along so bad: this was her home. Adora really couldn't imagine living here: it was more like a museum than it was a house.

After getting a tour of the house (which Glimmer emphasized was *very* brief, promising to give a lengthier one another day), they both made their way back to the dining room at the center of the house. Glimmer gave her hand a squeeze, as if to silently promise her that everything would be okay, then took her seat at the head of the table, to the left of Angella. The two seats to the right of the president were still empty.

Most of the hockey team had shown up already, and Adora recognized a few people. Most of the open seats were near the head of the table, so she ended up sitting next to a buff, quieter junior named Rogelio. He was one of the few people who hadn't pestered her to open up more, and Adora respected him for it. Plus, he was a mean goalie. He nodded a cool hello to her, then went back to looking at his phone.

President Angella was engaged in conversation with Coach Razz, who sat diagonally opposite of Adora. They were both laughing, and she remembered hearing something about the two being friends. Angella's sky blue and maroon flowing dress seemed to contrast Glimmer's, and Adora found herself wondering if they had color coordinated their outfits beforehand. Subtle beauty and confidence radiated off her in waves. It was clear who was in charge here, but Angella managed to pull off her aura of authority in a way that wasn't overly pushy.

As the small talk at the table quieted down, a tall, pale man Adora didn't know walked into the room. He was dressed in much more expensive clothes than everyone else at the table: a white suit with an intricate pattern of wilting roses, ironed to perfection, and a deep green tie. His long gray hair was braided back with silver rings. He took the seat two away from Angella at the head of the table, making a big show of pulling it out and brushing it off thoroughly before sitting down. Whereas Angella came across as an inviting host, this man came across as overly pompous and arrogant. He shot a piercing look at Angella as he sat down, but she didn't let her cool gaze slip. Adora couldn't help but wonder about the seat between them that still stood empty.

Angella stood up and began talking loudly, her voice reverberating through the room. "Welcome, Brightmoon hockey team. As many of you know, I am the president of this college. You may call me Angella. Seated to my right," Angella said, gesturing to the silvery man who looked bemused, "is your Vice President, Prime. To my left sits my daughter, Glimmer." Glimmer stood up and took a little bow, before sitting back down.

"Your first game is tomorrow, as I'm sure you are all aware. I felt it necessary to organize a team dinner in your honor. Hockey has become the sport which Brightmoon takes the most pride in the past few years, and I've heard good things from Coach Razz about some of our freshmen players," she said, glancing at Adora. "I'm sure they will make us proud when they take our team to victory."

Adora gulped. Angella had looked directly at her when she spoke. Sure she was a good player, but Adora couldn't help but feel like that was a lot of weight to put on the shoulders of a freshman. She caught Prime's gaze boring into her out of the corner of her eye.

"Anything to add, Prime?" Angella asked him cooly.

Prime stood up, a thin smile stretching across his face. "I have allocated funding from a few particularly generous anonymous donors to purchase a new coach bus with bag storage and onboard facilities for the hockey team's exclusive use." As the team erupted into applause, he sat back down with a smirk.

"Thank you prime, Angella said, looking just as surprised as the rest of the team. As she sat back down, Adora thought she could hear Angella sternly mumble, "we will talk about this later," to Prime.

When the applause died down, Angella spoke again. "Now, I do believe we have a feast in order. Good faith to Brightmoon!" she said, raising her glass and clinking it to Glimmers, then across the table to Coach Razz's, then to Prime's. Adora's teammates began toasting around her too, and she joined in. Maybe this dinner wasn't so bad after all.

The dinner was, in fact, great. The campus had catered from an Italian restaurant nearby, so there were an overwhelming amount of options for Adora to choose from. Grabbing a plate of carbs, she sat back down and started feasting away. The catered food was a million times better than the slop that the dining hall served, so she plowed down as much as she could.

Halfway through her first plate, she noticed Prime staring at her again. The only thing on his plate was a scoop of melting Italian ice. When he noticed Adora looking back, he spoke up.

"I've heard great things about you, Adora," he mused, propping his elbow up on the table and elevating his hand. "Many people

have been saying that you're the most promising player to join the hockey team in years. What do *you* think about that?"

Adora couldn't quite tell if his tone was patronizing or serious, and something about the way he looked at her was deeply unsettling. She didn't know how to reply.

Eventually she simply said, "I'm not sure about that, but I do think I'm a good player," matching his gaze.

"I happen to know a thing or two about hockey," he said softly, "and I've watched the team practice a few times this past week. You're much better than you're letting on."

Adora didn't respond. Why would he ask her something she already knew?

His eyes continued boring into her. "Are you feeling alright?" he asked after a moment of her silence. "I've noticed you zoning off an awful lot tonight. We wouldn't want you to get sick before the big game," he added in a strange tone.

Adora couldn't figure out what this guy's problem was. "No, I'm fine," she assured him.

Prime continued. "It's not an illness, though, is it? I can see it in your eyes… you're lovesick," he eventually decided.

Adora's ears started buzzing with anger. He had overstepped. "That's none of your business," she snapped.

Thankfully, Prime dropped the matter and went back to nibbling at the Italian ice. But Adora had lost her appetite. When she was done eating, she quickly dismissed herself from the table and stepped outside. The cool nighttime breeze refreshed her and cleared her mind.

Adora heard someone say, "Hey, Adora," behind her. She whipped around, but it was just Glimmer.

“Are you sure you’re feeling alright?” she asked. “What did Prime want with you?”

Adora sighed. “I don’t know. Do you think he’s a little…”

“...Unsettling?” Glimmer said, finishing Adora’s sentence.

“...yeah,” Adora said.

“He’s always kind of been that way,” Glimmer said, leaning over the railing next to Adora. “I remember when he first became vice president when I was little, I’d have nightmares about him. And my mom has fought with him over a lot of administrative stuff over the years.” She stopped talking and glanced over to Adora. “I didn’t tell you that, though,” she said quickly. “I could get in big trouble if you repeat that.”

“Don’t worry, I won’t.” Adora reassured her. “I think I might head back to the dorm and get some rest. I’m not really feeling this dinner anymore,” Adora said.

“Do you want me to come with you?” Glimmer offered.

Adora sighed. “No, you’re fine. Stay here and catch up with your mom some more.”

After Glimmer asked her if she was sure and Adora repeated that she was, Glimmer went back inside and Adora started the short walk back to their dorm. Her mind kept wandering to Catra. Adora wondered what she could possibly be doing right now.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry about the lack of updates, I've been pretty obsessed with baldurs gate 3 these past few days (highly recommend if you're considering picking it up).
>
> Have a great day/night!

Farewell

Chapter Summary

The end

Chapter Notes

Special thank you to Billie for releasing her new album and getting me back into the headspace to (finally) finish this fic. It's an abridged version of what I originally wanted to write and I only did some bare bones editing but I hope you enjoy it, nonetheless.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's hand clutched the orange.

It was strange that something as simple as a fruit could have that much pull on her. It was the same orange from those days ago, but its flesh had grown weak and discolored. Not unlike the hand that clutched it.

Her skin had become slightly paler, and it clung to her arm in a way that made it hard to recognize as her own. Her nails had become cracked and brittle, and her hair unkempt and patchy. All changes that had been brought about by her new diet. Or rather, her lack of diet. Throughout the course of her voluntary starvation, though, she held onto the orange. It was a reminder of just how close she'd been to truly being happy. A couple times, she'd almost given in and eaten it. It was a lot easier to resist that now that it had lost it's citrusy scent.

She'd long stopped attending her classes. They were just a waste of energy. Instead, Catra spent her days in the various utility closets around campus. There were sixty two total, and she'd visited them all. She particularly liked the one below the cafe, where a leaky water pipe dripped in an odd tune on the cement floor. Once or twice a week, she'd sneak into her dorm room while

classes were in session and move some things around, just so Scorpia knew she was still alive. The last thing she wanted was to get public safety on her ass. She imagined their fake worried glances and grimaced in disgust.

Catra's skeletal hand found it's way instinctively to the jacket pocket that held her phone before slipping back out. It had been dead for around a week now, and she hadn't cared nearly enough to charge it.

Her mind wandered back to the last day she'd checked it. The day Prime had offered to drive her to class a second time. Despite her attempts to explain to him that she no longer went to that class, he had insisted and into the car she went. A shiver ran down Catra's spine as she remembered his words.

"Adora is the best player this university's seen since my disgrace of a son."

Then, the kicker.

"She's destined for greatness. You intrude on that greatness. Let her go."

His last words were spoken as a command rather than a suggestion, and they'd loomed around her like a dark cloud. Because weren't they true? What had she truly offered Adora that she couldn't get with somebody else? *Anybody* else?
Catra felt tears fall from her eyes, but she had stopped feeling anything but hunger days ago. Her stomach felt like a ravenous beast, screaming and gnawing and piercing through her with each passing second. It was all part of her plan though. It would be so much easier if she just focused on the hunger.

Orange still in hand, Catra opened the door of the utility closet she'd been sitting in. The rusted hinge creaked slightly as it opened, but there was nobody else in the hallway to hear it. A faint ray of moonlight shone through the buildings expansive windows, causing Catra to shield her face as her eyes adjusted to

the change in light. She walked down the barren hallway, already tidied by the custodial staff for the next day of classes.

Quiet footsteps echoed around her, the untied laces clicking against the linoleum floor lightly as she made her way to the stairwell. It was another relic of the school's past, much like the abandoned utility closets she'd become so accustomed with. The main elevator shaft ran up and down the core of the six story building, but that area crawled with public safety officers at this time of night, and her work required no interruption.

Catra's chest heaved as she climbed flight after flight of stairs. The first time she'd made this trek, it had taken her two and a half minutes to climb them all. She was barely winded by the time she'd reached the top. This time, she was winded after the first flight and had to take a breather. The breaths came out ragged and dry. She continued, her head spinning after the third or fourth break. Finally, she made it up to the last level, catching herself from falling over on the railing. She peered down between the stairs. The floor seemed so far from here.

After gathering herself again, Catra took a left, then a right. She stopped in front of the ladder, a sign next to it labeled in bold red letters that said "ROOF ACCESS." It was here that she eased herself to the ground, her back slumping against the cinder block wall. She dug around in her other pocket, full of random junk she'd pocketed from her room. Among those belongings was a yellowed piece of paper. It had been folded and unfolded so many times the creases had begun to cut into the fiber that made it up. She didn't need to unfold it to know what was scrawled onto it: the image was burned into her eyes from how much she'd been staring at it.

The paper wasn't what she was after, though. Nor the lone ukulele string, nor the orange, nor the bloodied razor blade. Beneath it was a charging cord. She plugged the power brick into the wall, and her phone into the cord.
While her phone charged, Catra heaved herself up to her feet and made her way to the ladder. Although it took great effort, she put

one hand over the other, then a foot, and in a concerningly short amount of time she was catching her breath at the top and staring at the steely metal hatch above her. She raised her arm and pulled it down.

Immediately, the hatch unfolded, and cold air swept into the building. Catra carefully descended the ladder, grabbed her phone and placed it in her pocket, then ascended the ladder once again. She didn't bother grabbing the power brick.

Her head poked out from within the building and surveyed the roof. It was mostly flat gravel, save for a few air conditioning units that stuck up. She pulled herself up and kicked the hatch until it shut. The wind was strong and loud up here: almost loud enough to drown out the noises telling her to stop, to go back down the ladder and back into the silent utility closet.

She ambled over to the edge of the rooftop and peered down at the ground, where grass met pavement. It must have rained during the day because both appeared slightly damp. Then, she reached into her pocket and withdrew everything. String, razor, orange, paper, phone. She'd rehearsed this next part in her head so many times it started off as second nature.

The first thing she threw over was the ukulele string. It caught on the wind and breezed down somewhere into the grass. Seeing it flutter through the night air sent a barely receptible pang through her chest, drowned out by the ravenous gnawing in her stomach.

She threw the razor blade next, with the knowledge that someone might step on it. A faint smirk flitted across her face at the thought.

Next came the orange. She clutched it in one hand, some primal, animalistic urge deep in the recesses of her brain screaming at her for throwing away food when she was this malnourished. In one motion she raised her arm and lobbed it as far as she could, disappearing into the night.

Last she pulled out the drawing and unfolded it. It was silly really, holding onto something that stupid for that long. Especially now. The thought of being found with the paper on her, of Adora *knowing* she died with the drawing in her pocket would be enough to break the stupid golden retriever of a woman. So, she held it before her with both hands and gazed at it one last time. Then, she began to pull it apart.

More tears flowed down her face. She pulled slow at first: a little crevice in the middle that had already begun to tear widened until it was halfway down the page, then the entire way. What had once been one paper was now two. She stared at the halves and felt panic rising in her throat. She quickly tore the two into four, then four into eight. Each successive tear felt like ripping a limb from her body. Eight turned into sixteen, and then Catra loosened her fingers. The scraps of paper fluttered through the midnight breeze, lost to the wind forever.

Finally, she reached for her phone. It's screen was off, dark and inky as the nighttime sky above her. The emptiness was comforting in a way. She'd deliberated for a long time on whether or not to check if Adora had messaged her first, ultimately decided that knowing conclusively would make it that much easier to follow through, if in the moment her prior measures hadn't been enough.
She held her breath and hovered a numb finger over the screen. Why was it so hard to turn the screen on?

Catra fought back the urge to throw the phone over right then and there, and pressed the screen. A flashbang of light flooded her vision. When she could see clearly again, she saw the alert notifying that she was indeed at 1% battery. She entered her password with trembling fingers, four sixes.

Her heart stopped as she saw the 51 new messages from Adora.

Adora
Friday 10:15 AM
Catra I think I’m ready to talk now

Adora
Friday 10:16 AM
If you’re ready too

Adora
Friday 10:32 AM
I’m really sorry I blocked you but I just needed some space and I hope you can understand that

Adora
Friday 10:33 AM
Are you doing ok at least

Adora
Friday 3:17 PM
If you’re angry at me that’s ok but I have a hockey game on Sunday and I was hoping you could come to it

Adora
Friday 3:19 PM
Maybe we could talk after?

Adora
Friday 3:22 PM
I reserved a ticket for you if you want to come, I’ll send it to you

Adora
Friday 3:23 PM
[link:brightmoonticketbooth.com]

Adora
Friday 11:32 PM
I really do hope you’re doing okay

Tears streamed down Catra's face, and her breaths came out in sobs that racked her entire body. She took a moment to stop and wipe them away with the corner of her sleeve. The rooftop winds bit at her skin, but she desperately scanned her phone screen for more texts.

Adora
Friday 11:48 PM
Goodnight

Adora
Saturday 9:32 AM
Just woke up I'm gonna grab some food at the dining hall

Adora
Saturday 9:34 AM
I'd love to meet you there, Bow and Glimmer are visiting Bows dads today

Adora
Saturday 6:24 PM
I know you're probably still mad but I was serious about-

Catra's phone blinked off, an unhappy looking drained battery popping up on the now black screen. For a moment, she saw her unkempt reflection on the phone's screen The roof was flooded in darkness again. She stared at it, her thinned fingers clutching at the phone like a lifeline.

Chapter End Notes

I had wanted to write an ambiguous ending to this fic originally, but I decided to write an epilogue too. More fics coming soon c: <3

Castle

Chapter Summary

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra sneezed. Her immune system hadn't quite been right, even after however long she'd spent in this damn hospital. It really wasn't so bad, though. The nurses were kind and the food wasn't horrible. Sometimes there were even little cups of mandarin oranges. Adora visited every day after class, and she had time to pluck her ukulele until her fingers were raw. The University had put her on academic probation, not the worst outcome by a long shot.

A faint smile flitted across her face as she looked over at her nightstand. Amidst the various medications, the IV line, and that same phone charger sat a miniature canvas with a lion painted on it. Adora had always been the better artist, even if she didn't want to admit it.

Chapter End Notes

More fics coming soon

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!